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ROMAN THEATRE

PLAUTUS

The Rope

Playwright	Plautus
Translated by	Henry Thomas Riley
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The digital text is Perseus's TEI encoding of Riley, published under CC BY-SA 4.0;
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The only Roman comedy with a sea in it, and the one Plautus set in Africa. Arcturus speaks the prologue and claims responsibility for the storm, which is a neat way of saying the plot is a moral one.

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Riley's notes are collected at the end of this text.

Dramatis Personae

ARCTURUS, who speaks the Prologue.
DAEMONES, an aged Athenian, now living at .
PLESIDIPPUS, a young Athenian, in love with Palaestra.

SCEPARNIO, Servants of Daemones.
GRIPUS,
TURBALIO,
SPARAX,
TRACHALIO, the servant of Plesidippus.
LABRAX, a Procurer.
CHARMIDES, a Sicilian, his guest.
FISHERMEN of Cyrene.
PTOLEMOCRATIA, Priestess of Venus.

PALAESTRA, Young women in the possession of Labrax.
AMPELISCA,

((Scene.—Near Cyrene, in Africa ; not far from the sea-shore, and before the cottage of DAEMONES and the Temple of Venus, which has, probably, a small court before it, surrounded with a low wall.))

THE SUBJECT
DAEMONES, an aged Athenian, having lost his property, goes to live in retirement near the sea-shore of Cyrene, in the vicinity of the Temple of Venus. It so happens that Labrax, a Procurer, makes purchase of two damsels, Palaestra and Ampelisca, and comes to reside at Cyrene. Plesidippus, a young Athenian, sees Palaestra there, and falls in love with her; and making an arrangement with the Procurer, gives him a sum in part payment for her, on which occasion, Labrax invites him to a sacrifice in the Temple of Venus. A Sicilian guest of his, however, named Charmides, persuades him to carry the young women over to Sicily, where he is sure to make a greater profit by them. On this, the Procurer, accompanied by his guest, sets sail with them. A tempest arises, and they are shipwrecked. The young women escape in a boat, and arriving ashore, are hospitably received by the Priestess of Venus. Labrax and Charmides also escape, and on discovering where the women are, the former attempts to drag them by force from the Temple. On this they are protected by Daemones and Plesidippus, who, through Trachalio, finds out where they are. In the wreck a wallet has been lost, which belongs to Labrax, and in which is a casket enclosing some trinkets belonging to Palaestra. Gripus, a servant of Daemones, draws this up with the rope attached to his net; and by means of these trinkets it is discovered that Palaestra is the daughter of Daemones, whom he had lost in her infancy; on which she is given in marriage to Plesidippus by her father, who becomes reconciled to Labrax.

THE ACROSTIC ARGUMENT. [1]
A FISHERMAN draws a wallet out of the sea in his net (Reti), in which (Ubi) are the trinkets of his master’s daughter, who, having been stolen, had come into the possession of a Procurer as her owner (Dominum). She (Ea), having suffered shipwreck (Naufragio), without knowing it comes under the protection of her own father; she is recognized, and is married to her (Suo) lover Plesidippus.

ARCTURUS

[2] WITH him who sways all nations, seas, and lands, I am a fellow-citizen in the realms of the Gods. I am, as you see [3] , a bright and shining star, a Constellation that ever in its season rises
here on earth and in the heavens. Arcturus is my name. By night, I am glittering in the heavens and amid the Gods, passing among mortals in the day. Other Constellations, too, descend from the heavens upon the earth; Jove, who is the ruler of Gods and men—
he disperses us here in various directions among the nations, to observe the actions, manners, piety, and faith of men, just as the means of each avail him. Those who commence villanous suits at law upon false testimony, and those who, in court, upon false oath deny a debt,
their names written down, do we return to Jove. Each day does he learn who here is calling for vengeance. Whatever wicked men seek here to gain their cause through perjury, who succeed before the judge in their unjust demands, the same case adjudged does he judge over again,
and he fines them in a penalty much greater than the results of the judgment they have gained. The good men written down on other tablets [4] does he keep. And still these wicked persons entertain a notion of theirs, that they are able to appease Jupiter with gifts, with sacrifice; both their labour and their cost they lose. This, for this reason, is so,
because no petition of the perjured is acceptable to Him. If any person that is supplicating the Deities is pious, he will more easily procure pardon for himself than he that is wicked. Therefore I do advise you this, you who are good and who pass your lives in piety and in virtue—
still persevere, that one day you may rejoice that so you did. Now, the reason for which I’ve come hither, I will disclose to you. First, then, Diphilus [5] has willed the name of this city to be Cyrene [6] . There ((pointing to the cottage)) dwells Daemones, in the country and in a cottage very close adjoining to the sea,
an old gentleman who has come hither in exile from Athens, no unworthy man. And still, not for his bad deserts has he left his country, but while he was aiding others, meanwhile himself he embarrassed: a property honorably acquired he lost by his kindly ways. Long since, his daughter, then a little child, was lost;
a most villanous fellow bought her of the thief, and this Procurer [7] brought the maiden hither to Cyrene. A certain Athenian youth, a citizen of this city, beheld her as she was going home from the music-school. He begins to love her; to the Procurer he comes;
he purchases the damsel for himself at the price of thirty minae, and gives him earnest, and binds the Procurer with an oath. This Procurer, just as befitted him, did not value at one straw his word, or what, on oath, he had said to the young man. He had a guest, a fit match for himself, an old man of Sicily,
a rascal from Agrigentum [8] , a traitor to his native city; this fellow began to extol the beauty of that maiden, and of the other damsels, too, that were belonging to him. On this he began to persuade the Procurer to go together with himself to Sicily; he said that there the men were given to pleasure;
that there he might be enabled to become a wealthy man; that there was the greatest profit from courtesans. He prevails. A ship is hired by stealth. Whatever he has, by night the Procurer carries it on board ship from his house; the young man who purchased the damsel of him
he has told that he is desirous of performing a vow to Venus. This is the Temple of Venus, here ((pointing at it)) , and here, for that reason, has he invited the youth hither to a breakfast [9] . From there at once did he embark on board ship, and he carried off the courtesans. Some other persons informed the young man what things were going on,
how that the Procurer had departed. When the young man came to the harbour, their ship had got a great way out to sea. When I beheld how that the maiden was being carried off, I brought at the same instant both relief to her and destruction to the Procurer; the storm I rebuked, and the waves of the sea I aroused.
For the most violent Constellation of them all am I, Arcturus; turbulent I am when rising, when I set, more turbulent still. Now, cast ashore there, both the Procurer and his guest are sitting upon a rock; their ship is dashed to pieces. But this maiden, and another as well, her attendant, affrighted, have leaped from the ship into a boat. At this moment the waves are bringing them from the rocks to land, to the cottage of this old man, who is living here

in exile, whose roof and tiles the storm has stript off. And this is his servant who is coming out of doors.
The youth will be here just now, and you shall see him, who purchased the maiden of the Procurer. Now, fare ye well, and may your foes [10] distrust themselves. ((Exit.))

((Enter SCEPARNIO, with a spade on his shoulder.))

SCEPARNIO
((to himself.))
O ye immortal Gods, what a dreadful tempest has Neptune sent us this last night!
The storm has unroofed the cottage. What need of words is there? It was no storm, but what Alcmena met with in Euripides [11] ; it has so knocked all the tiles from off the roof; more light has it given us, and has added to our windows.

((Enter PLESIDIPPUS, at a distance, talking with three CITIZENS.))

PLESIDIPPUS
I have both withdrawn you from your avocations,
and that has not succeeded on account of which I've brought you; I could not catch the Procurer down at the harbour. But I have been unwilling to abandon all hope by reason of my remissness; on that account, my friends, have I the longer detained you. Now hither to the Temple of Venus am I come to see,
where he was saying that he was about to perform a sacrifice.

SCEPARNIO
((aloud to himself, at a distance.))
If I am wise, I shall be getting ready this clay that is awaiting me. ((Falls to work digging.))

PLESIDIPPUS
((looking round.))
Some one, I know not who, is speaking near to me. ((Enter DAEMONES, from his house.))

DAEMONES
Hallo! Sceparnio!

SCEPARNIO
Who's calling me by name?

DAEMONES
He who paid his money for you.

SCEPARNIO
((turning round.))
As though you would say, Daemones, that I am your slave.

DAEMONES
There's occasion for plenty of clay [12] , therefore dig up plenty of earth. I find that the whole of my cottage must be covered; for now it's shining through it, more full of holes than a sieve.

PLESIDIPPUS

((advancing.))
Health to you, good father, and to both of you, indeed.

DAEMONES
Health to you.

SCEPARNIO
((to PLESIDIPPUS, who is muffled up in a coat.))
But whether are you male or female, who are calling him father?

PLESIDIPPUS
Why really, I’m a man.

DAEMONES
Then, man, go seek a father elsewhere.
I once had an only daughter, that only one I lost. Of the male sex I never had a child.

PLESIDIPPUS
But the Gods will give—

SCEPARNIO
((going on digging.))
A heavy mischance to you indeed, I’ faith, whoever you are, who are occupying us, already occupied, with your prating.

PLESIDIPPUS
((pointing to the cottage.))
Pray are you dwelling there?

SCEPARNIO
Why do you ask that? Are you reconnoitring the place for you to come and rob there?

PLESIDIPPUS
It befits a slave to be right rich in his savings, whom, in the presence of his master, the conversation cannot escape, or who is to speak rudely to a free man.

SCEPARNIO
And it befits a man to be shameless and impudent, for him to whom there’s nothing owing, of his own accord to come to the house of another person annoying people.

DAEMONES
Sceparnio, hold your tongue.
((To PLESIDIPPUS.)) What do you want, young man?

PLESIDIPPUS
A mishap to that fellow, who is in a hurry to be the first to speak when his master’s present.
But, unless it’s troublesome, I wish to make enquiry of you in a few words.

DAEMONES
My attention shall be given you, even though in the midst of business.

SCEPARNIO
((to PLESIDIPPUS.))
Rather, be off with you to the marsh, and cut down some reeds [13] , with which we may cover the cottage, while it is fine weather.

DAEMONES
Hold your tongue. Do you tell me ((to PLESIDIPPUS)) if you have need of anything.

PLESIDIPPUS
Inform me on what I ask you;
whether you have seen here any frizzle-headed fellow, with grey hair, a worthless, perjured, fawning knave.

DAEMONES
Full many a one; for by reason of fellows of that stamp am I living in misery.

PLESIDIPPUS
Him, I mean, who brought with him to the Temple of Venus here two young women, and who was to make preparations for himself
to perform a sacrifice either to-day or yesterday.

DAEMONES
By my faith, young man, for these very many days past I haven’t seen any one sacrificing there; and yet it can’t be unknown to me if any one does sacrifice there. They are always asking here for water, or for fire, or for vessels, or for a knife, or for a spit,
or for a pot for cooking [14] , or something or other. What need is there of words? I procured my vessels and my well, for the use of Venus, and not my own. There has now been a cessation of it for these many days past.

PLESIDIPPUS
According to the words you utter, you tell me I’m undone.

DAEMONES
Really, so far as I’m concerned, I’ faith, you may be safe and sound.

SCEPARNIO
((stopping in his digging.))
Hark you, you that are roaming about Temples for the sake of your stomach, ’twere better for you to order a breakfast to be got ready at home.
Perhaps you’ve been invited here [15] to breakfast. He that invited you, hasn’t he come at all?

PLESIDIPPUS
’Tis the fact.

SCEPARNIO
There’s no risk then in your betaking yourself hence home without your breakfast.
It’s better for you to be a waiter upon Ceres than upon Venus; the latter attends to love, Ceres attends to wheat.

PLESIDIPPUS
((to DAEMONES.))
This fellow has been making sport of me in a digraceful manner.

DAEMONES
((looking out at the side.))
O ye immortal Gods, Sceparnio, what means those people near the sea-shore?

SCEPARNIO
According to my notion,
they’ve been invited to a parting breakfast [16] .

DAEMONES
How so?

SCEPARNIO
Why, because, after dinner, I fancy, they yesterday washed themselves clean;
their ship has gone to pieces out at sea.

DAEMONES
((looking steadfastly.))
Such is the fact.

SCEPARNIO
But, I’ faith, on dry land our cottage and tiles have done the same.

DAEMONES
Oh dear! what unfortunate creatures you are; ((to SCEPARNIO)) how the shipwrecked people are swimming.

PLESIDIPPUS
Prithee, where are these people?

DAEMONES
((pointing to the distance.))
This way, to the right; don’t you see them near the shore?

PLESIDIPPUS
((looking the same way.))
I see them; ((to his FRIENDS)) follow me. I only wish it may be he that I’m seeking, that most accursed fellow.
((To DAEMONES and SCEPARNIO.)) Fare you well.

SCEPARNIO
If you hadn’t put us in mind, we should have thought of that ourselves.
((Exeunt PLESIDIPPUS and FRIENDS. SCEPARNIO looks out towards the sea.))
But, O Palaemon [17] , hallowed associate of Neptune, who art said to be the partner of Hercules, what shocking thing do I see?

DAEMONES
What do you see?

SCEPARNIO
I see two young women sitting in a boat alone. How the poor things are being tossed about That’s good, that’s good, well done.
The surge is driving the boat away from the rock towards the shore. Not a pilot could have ever done it better. I don’t think that I ever saw billows more huge. They are saved, if they can escape those waves. Now, now’s the danger; it has sent one overboard!
See you that one whom the waves have thrown out of the boat?
Still, she’s in a shallow place; she’ll easily wade through it now. O capital!
now she’s safe; she has escaped from the water; she’s now on shore. But that other one has now sprung towards the land from the boat—from her alarm she has fallen into the waves upon her knees.
She has got up again; if she takes this direction, the matter’s safe; ((a pause)) but she has taken to the right, to utter destruction. Ah, she will be wandering all the day—

DAEMONES
What signifies that to you?

SCEPARNIO
If she should fall down from that rock towards which she is wending her way,
she’ll be putting a period to her wandering.

DAEMONES
If you are about to dine this evening at their expense, I think you may then be concerned for them, Sceparnio; if you are going to eat at my house, I wish your services to be devoted to myself.

SCEPARNIO
You ask what’s good and proper.

DAEMONES
Then follow me this way.

SCEPARNIO
I follow [18] . ((Exeunt.))

((Enter PALAESTRA, at a distance, with her clothes torn and drenched.))

PALAESTRA
((to herself.))
By heavens, the mishaps of mortals are spoken of as much less bitter than the sharp pangs that are inflicted in the experience of them Has this then pleased the Deity, that I, clad in this guise, should, in my terror, be cast upon a spot unknown? Shall I then declare that I have been born to this wretched lot?
Do I receive this meed in return for my exemplary piety? For to me it would not prove a hardship to endure this laborious lot, if I had conducted myself undutifully towards my parents or the Gods; but if studiously I have exerted myself to beware of that, then, unduly and unjustly,
Deities, you send upon me this. For what henceforth shall the glaringly impious receive, if after this fashion you pay honor to the guiltless? But if I knew that I or my parents had done anything wicked, now should I have grieved

the less. But the wickedness of this master of mine is pressing hard upon me, his impiety is causing my woes; everything has he lost in the sea;
these are the remains ((looking at her dress)) of his property. Even she, who was carried together with me in the boat, was washed out by the violence of the waves; I am now alone. If she at least [19] had been saved for me, through her aid my affliction here would have been lighter to me. Now, what hope or aid or what counsel shall I receive,
a spot so lonesome here have I lighted upon alone? Here are the rocks, here roars the sea, and not one individual comes across my path. This dress that I am clothed in forms all my riches quite entirely; nor know I with what food or roof I am to be provided. What hope have I through which to desire to live?
Neither am I acquainted with the place, nor was I ever here before. At least I could have wished for some one who would point out to me either a road or a path from these spots; so much am I now at a loss for advice whether to go this way or that; neither, indeed, do I see [20] anywhere near here a cultivated spot.
Cold, distraction, and alarm, have taken possession of all my limbs. My parents, you know not of this, that I am now thus wretched; I that was born a woman entirely free, was so to no purpose. Am I at all the less in servitude now, than if I had been born a slave? And never in any way has it been a profit to those who for their own sakes reared me up. ((She advances forward, and rests on one side against the cliff.))

((Enter AMPELISCA, at a distance, on the other side of the stage, in a similar condition.))

AMPELISCA
((to herself.))
What is there better for me, what more to my advantage, than to shut out life from my body? So wretched am I in my existence, and so many deadening cares are there in my breast; so despicable is my lot; I care not for my life; I have lost the hope with which I used to comfort myself. All places have I now rambled about, and through each covert spot have I crawled along, to seek my fellow-slave with voice, eyes, ears, that I might trace her out.
And still I find her nowhere, nor have I yet determined whither to go, nor where to seek her, nor, in the meantime, do I find any person here to give me an answer, of whom I might make enquiry. No place, too, is there on earth more solitary than are these spots and this locality. And yet, if she lives, never while I exist will I cease before I discover her alive.

PALAESTRA
((aloud.))
Whose voice is it that sounds close by me here?

AMPELISCA
((starting.))
I am alarmed. Who’s speaking near me?

PALAESTRA
Prithee, kind Hope, do come to my aid.

AMPELISCA
It’s a woman: a woman’s voice reaches my ears.
Will you not rescue wretched me from this alarm?

PALAESTRA
Surely a woman’s voice reached my ears.
Prithee is it Ampelisca?

AMPELISCA
Is it you, Palaestra, that I hear?

PALAESTRA
But why don’t I call her by her own name, that she may hear me? ((With a loud voice.)) Ampelisca!

AMPELISCA
Ha! who’s that?

PALAESTRA
’Tis I.

AMPELISCA
Is it Palaestra? [21]

PALAESTRA
It is.

AMPELISCA
Tell me where [22] you are.

PALAESTRA
Troth, I’m now in the midst of a multitude of woes.

AMPELISCA
I am your partner; and no less is my own share than yours.
But I long to see you.

PALAESTRA
In that wish you are my rival.

AMPELISCA
Let’s follow our voices with our steps; where are you?

PALAESTRA
See, here am I. Step onward towards me, and come straight on to meet me.

AMPELISCA
I’m doing so with care. ((They meet in front of the stage.))

PALAESTRA
Give me your hand.

AMPELISCA
Take it.

PALAESTRA

Are you still alive? Prithee, tell me.

AMPELISCA
You, indeed, make me now wish to live,
since I'm empowered to touch you. How hardly can I persuade myself of this, that I am holding you. Prithee, do embrace me ((they embrace)) , my only hope; how you are now easing me of all my woes.

PALAESTRA
You are beforehand with me in using expressions which belong to me. Now it befits us to be going hence.

AMPELISCA
Prithee, whither shall we go?

PALAESTRA
Let's keep along this sea-shore. ((Pointing to the shore.))

AMPELISCA
Wherever you please, I'll follow.

PALAESTRA
Shall we go along thus with our wet clothing?

AMPELISCA
That which exists, the same must of necessity be borne. ((Looking up at the Temple.)) But, pray, what's this?

PALAESTRA
What is it?

AMPELISCA
Prithee, don't you see this Temple? ((Pointing towards it.))

PALAESTRA
Where is it?

AMPELISCA
On the right hand.

PALAESTRA
I seem to be looking at a place becoming the Divinities.

AMPELISCA
There must be people not far hence; it is so delightful a spot. Whoever the God is, I pray him to relieve us from these troubles, and to succour us females, wretched, helpless, and in distress. ((They advance towards the Temple, and kneel down before it.))

((Enter PTOLEMOCRATIA, the Priestess, from the Temple of Venus.))

PTOLEMOCRATIA

Who are these, that in their prayers are soliciting aid from my Patroness?
For the voice of suppliants has brought me hither out of doors. They pay suit to a kind and compliant Goddess and a Patroness that makes no difficulties, and one who is very benevolent.

PALAESTRA
Mother, we bid you hail.

PTOLEMOCRATIA
Maidens, hail to you. But, prithee, whence
am I to say that you are hither come with your wet garments, thus wofully arrayed?

PALAESTRA
Just now, we came from a place there ((pointing towards the shore)) , not a great way from this spot; but it is a great way off from here, whence we have been brought hither.

PTOLEMOCRATIA
Have you been borne, do you mean, by a ship, the wooden steed [23] , over the azure paths?

PALAESTRA
Even so.

PTOLEMOCRATIA
Then it were more fitting that you should have come
arrayed in white and provided with victims; it isn't the practice for people to come to this Temple in that fashion. ((Pointing at their dresses.))

PALAESTRA
Prithee, whence would you have us, who have been both cast away at sea, to be bringing victims hither? Now, in want of assistance, do we embrace your knees,
we who are of hopes undefined in places unknown, that you may receive us under your roof and shelter us, and that you will pity the miseries of us both, who have neither any place of refuge nor hope at hand, nor have anything whatever of our own beyond that which you see.

PTOLEMOCRATIA
Give me your hands, arise, both of you, from off your knees; no one among women is more compassionate than I. ((They arise from the ground.)) But, maidens, my circumstances are poor and limited; with difficulty I support my own existence; Venus I serve for my maintenance.

AMPELISCA
Prithee, is this a Temple of Venus?

PTOLEMOCRATIA
I will admit it; I am styled the Priestess of this Temple. But whatever it is, it shall be done by me with a hearty welcome, so far as my means shall suffice. Come with me this way.

PALAESTRA
Kindly and attentively, mother, do you show your attentions to us.

PTOLEMOCRATIA
So I ought to do. ((They go into the Temple.))

((Ente some FISHERMEN, with lines and nets.))

A FISHERMAN
Persons who are poor live wretchedly in every way, especially those who have no calling and have learned no art. Of necessity must that be deemed enough, whatever they have at home. From our garb, then, you pretty well understand how wealthy we are. These hooks and these rods here are as good to us as a calling and as our clothing. Each day from the city do we come out hither to the sea to seek for forage. Instead of exertion in the wrestling-school and the place for exercise, we have this: sea-urchins, rock-mussels, oysters, limpets [24] , cockles, sea-nettles, sea-mussels and spotted crabs [25] , we catch. After that, we commence our fishing with the hook and among the rocks,
and thus we take our food from out of the sea. If success does not befall us, and not any fish is taken, soaked in salt water [26] and thoroughly drenched, we quietly betake ourselves home, and without dinner go to sleep. And since the sea is now in waves so boisterous, no hopes have we; unless we take some cockles, without a doubt we've had our dinners.
Now let's adore good Venus here, that she may kindly befriend us to-day.
((They advance towards the door of the Temple.))

((Enter TRACHALIO, at a distance, in haste.))

TRACHALIO
((to himself.))
I've carefully given all attention that I mightn't pass my master anywhere; for when some time since he went out of the house, he said that he was going to the harbour, and he ordered me to come here to meet him at the Temple of Venus. But see, opportunely do I espy some people standing here of whom I may enquire; I'll accost them. ((Goes up to the FISHERMEN.)) Save you, thieves of the sea, shellfish-gatherers and hook-fishers [27] , hungry race of men, how fare ye? How perish apace [28] ?

FISHERMEN of Cyrene
Just as befits a fisherman with hunger, thirst, and expectation.

TRACHALIO
Have you seen to-day, while you've been standing here, any young man, of courageous aspect, ruddy, stout, of genteel appearance, come by this way,
who was taking with him three men in scarfs, with swords?

FISHERMEN of Cyrene
We know of no one coming this way of that appearance which you mention.

TRACHALIO
Have you seen any old fellow, bald on the forehead and snub-nosed, of big stature, pot-bellied, with eyebrows awry, a narrow forehead, a knave, the scorn of Gods and men, a scoundrel, one full of vile dishonesty and of iniquity,
who had along with him two very pretty-looking young women?

FISHERMEN of Cyrene

One who has been born with qualities and endowments of that sort, ’twere really fitter for him to resort to the executioner than to the Temple of Venus.

TRACHALIO
But tell me if you have seen him.

FISHERMEN of Cyrene
Really, no one has passed this way. Fare you well.

TRACHALIO
Fare ye well. ((Exeunt FISHERMEN.)) ((to himself.)) I thought so; it has come to pass as I suspected;
my master has been deceived; the cursed Procurer has taken himself off to distant lands. He has embarked on board ship, and carried the women away; I’m a wizard. He invited my master here to breakfast, as well, this very spawn of wickedness. Now what is better for me than to wait here in this spot until my master comes? At the same time, if this Priestess of Venus knows anything more,
if I see her, I’ll make enquiries; she’ll give me the information.

((Enter AMPELISCA, from the Temple.))

AMPELISCA
((to the PRIESTESS, within.))
I understand; here at this cottage ((pointing to it)) , which is close by the Temple of Venus, you’ve requested me to knock and ask for water.

TRACHALIO
Whose voice is it that has flown to my ears?

AMPELISCA
Prithee, who’s speaking here? Who is it that I see?

TRACHALIO
Isn’t this Ampelisca that’s coming out from the Temple?

AMPELISCA
Isn’t this
Trachalio that I see, the servant of Plesidippus?

TRACHALIO
It is she.

AMPELISCA
It is he; Trachalio, health to you.

TRACHALIO
Health, Ampelisca, to you; how fare you?

AMPELISCA
In misery I pass a life not far advanced [29] .

TRACHALIO
Do give some better omen.

AMPELISCA
Still it behoves all prudent persons to confer and talk together. But, prithee, where’s your master, Plesidippus?

TRACHALIO
Marry, well said, indeed; as if he wasn’t within there. ((Pointing to the Temple.))

AMPELISCA
By my troth, he isn’t, nor, in fact, has he come here at all.

TRACHALIO
He hasn’t come?

AMPELISCA
You say the truth.

TRACHALIO
That’s not my way, Ampelisca. But how nearly is the breakfast got ready?

AMPELISCA
What breakfast, I beg of you?

TRACHALIO
The sacrifice, I mean, that you are performing here.

AMPELISCA
Prithee, what is it you are dreaming about?

TRACHALIO
For certain, Labrax invited Plesidippus hither to a breakfast, your master, my master.

AMPELISCA
By my troth, you’re telling of no wondrous facts: if he has deceived Gods and men, he has only acted after the fashion of Procurers.

TRACHALIO
Then neither yourselves nor my master are here performing a sacrifice.

AMPELISCA
You are a wizard.

TRACHALIO
What are you doing then?

AMPELISCA

The Priestess of Venus has received here into her abode both myself and Palaestra, after many mishaps and dreadful alarm, and from being in danger of our lives, destitute of aid and of resources.

TRACHALIO
Prithee, is Palaestra here, the beloved of my master?

AMPELISCA
Assuredly.

TRACHALIO
Great joyousness is there in your news, my dear Ampelisca. But I greatly long to know what was this danger of yours.

AMPELISCA
Last night our ship was wrecked, my dear Trachalio.

TRACHALIO
How, ship? What story’s this?

AMPELISCA
Prithee, have you not heard in what way the Procurer intended secretly to carry us away hence to Sicily, and how, whatever there was at home, he placed on board ship? That has all gone to the bottom now.

TRACHALIO
O clever Neptune, hail to thee! Surely, no dicer is more skilful than thyself. Decidedly
a right pleasant throw [30] hast thou made; thou didst break a-villain. But where now is the Procurer Labrax?

AMPELISCA
Perished through drinking, I suppose; Neptune last night invited him to deep potations.

TRACHALIO
By my troth, I fancy it was given him to drink by way of cup of necessity [31] . How much I do love you, my dear Ampelisca; how pleasing you are; what honied words you do utter.
But you and Palaestra, in what way were you saved?

AMPELISCA
I’ll let you know. Both in affright, we leapt from the ship into a boat, because we saw that the ship was being borne upon a rock; in haste, I unloosed the rope, while they were in dismay. The storm separated us from them with the boat in a direction to the right. And so, tossed about by winds and waves,
in a multitude of ways, we, wretched creatures, during the livelong night half dead, the wind this day has scarce borne us to the shore.

TRACHALIO
I understand; thus is Neptune wont to do; he is a very dainty Aedile [32] ; if any wares are bad, over he throws them all.

AMPELISCA
Woe to your head and life!

TRACHALIO
To your own, my dear Ampelisca. I was sure that the Procurer would do that which he has done; I often said so. It were better I should let my hair grow [33] , and set up for a soothsayer.

AMPELISCA
Did you not take care then, you and your master, that he shouldn’t go away, when you knew this?

TRACHALIO
What could he do?

AMPELISCA
If he was in love, do you ask what he could do?
Both night and day he should have kept watch; he should have been always on his guard. But, by my troth, he has done like many others; thus finely has Plesidippus taken care of her.

TRACHALIO
For what reason do you say that?

AMPELISCA
The thing is evident.

TRACHALIO
Don’t you know this? Even he who goes to the bath to bathe, while there he carefully keeps an eye upon his garments, still they are stolen; inasmuch as some one of those that he is watching is a rogue;
the thief easily marks him for whom he’s upon the watch; the keeper knows not which one is the thief. But bring me to her; where is she?

AMPELISCA
Well then, go here into the Temple of Venus; you’ll find her sitting there, and in tears.

TRACHALIO
How disagreable is that to me already. But why is she weeping?

AMPELISCA
I’ll tell you; she’s afflicting herself in mind for this; because the Procurer took away a casket from her which she had,
and in which she kept that by which she might be enabled to recognize her parents; she fears that this has been lost.

TRACHALIO
Where was that little casket, pray?

AMPELISCA
There, on board the ship; he himself locked it up in his wallet, that there mightn’t be the means by which she might recognize her parents.

TRACHALIO

O scandalous deed! to require her to be a slave, who ought to be a free woman.

AMPELISCA
Therefore she now laments that it has gone to the bottom along with the ship. There, too, was all the gold and silver of the Procurer.

TRACHALIO
Some one, I trust, has dived and brought it up.

AMPELISCA
For this reason is she sad and disconsolate, that she has met with the loss of them.

TRACHALIO
Then have I the greater occasion to do this, to go in and console her, that she mayn't thus distress herself in mind. For I know that many a lucky thing has happened to many a one beyond their hopes.

AMPELISCA
But I know too that hope has deceived many who have hoped.

TRACHALIO
Therefore a patient mind is the best remedy for affliction. I'll go in, unless you wish for anything. ((Goes into the Temple.))

AMPELISCA
Go. ((To herself.)) I'll do that which the Priestess requested me, and I'll ask for some water here at the neighbour's;
for she said that if I asked for it in her name, they would give it directly. And I do think that I never saw a more worthy old lady, one to whom I should think that it is more befitting for Gods and men to show kindness. How courteously, how heartily, how kindly, how, without the least difficulty, she received us into her home, trembling, in want, drenched, shipwrecked, half dead;
not otherwise, in fact, than if we had been her own offspring. How kindly did she herself, just now, tucking up her garments, make the water warm for us to bathe. Now, that I mayn't keep her waiting, I'll fetch some water from the place where she requested me. ((Knocking at the door of DAEMONES.)) Hallo, there, is there any one in the cottage? is any one going to open this door? Will any one come out?

((Enter SCEPARNIO, from the cottage of DAEMONES.))

SCEPARNIO
Who is it so furiously making an attack upon our door?

AMPELISCA
It's I.

SCEPARNIO
Well now, what good news is there? ((Aside.)) Dear me, a lass of comely appearance, i' troth.

AMPELISCA
Greeting to you, young man.

SCEPARNIO
And many greetings to you, young woman.

AMPELISCA
I’m come to you—

SCEPARNIO
I’ll receive you with a welcome, if you come in the evening, by-and-by, just such as I could like; for just now I’ve no means [34] to receive you, a damsel, thus early in the morning But what have you to say, my smiling, pretty one. ((Chucks her under the chin.))

AMPELISCA
Oh, you’re handling me too familiarly. ((Moves away.))

SCEPARNIO
O ye immortal Gods! she’s the very image of Venus. What joyousness there is in her eyes, and, only do see, what a skin ’tis of the vulture’s tint [35] ,—rather, the eagle’s, indeed, I meant to say. Her breasts, too, how beautiful; and then what expression on her lips! ((Takes hold of her.))

AMPELISCA
((struggling.))
I’m no common commodity for the whole township [36] ; can’t you keep your hands off me?

SCEPARNIO
((patting her.))
Won’t you let me touch you, gentle one, in this manner, gently and lovingly?

AMPELISCA
When I have leisure, then I’ll be giving my attention to toying and dalliance to please you; for the present, prithee, do either say me Yes or No to the matter for which I was sent hither.

SCEPARNIO
What now is it that you wish?

AMPELISCA
((pointing to her pitcher.))
To a shrewd person, my equipment would give indications of what it is I want.

SCEPARNIO
To a shrewd woman, this equipment, too, of mine, would give indication of what it is I want.

AMPELISCA
((pointing to the Temple.))
The Priestess there of Venus, requested me to fetch some water from your house here.

SCEPARNIO
But I’m a lordly sort of person; unless you entreat me, you shan’t have a drop. We dug this well with danger to

ourselves, and with tools of iron. Not a drop can be got out of me except by means of plenty of blandishments.

AMPELISCA
Prithee, why do you make so much fuss about the water—a thing that even enemy affords to enemy?

SCEPARNIO
Why do you make so much fuss about granting a favour to me, that citizen grants to citizen?

AMPELISCA
On the contrary, my sweet one, I'll even do everything for you that you wish.

SCEPARNIO
O charming! I am favoured; she's now calling me her sweet one. The water shall be given you, so that you mayn't be coaxing me in vain. Give me the pitcher.

AMPELISCA
Take it ((gives it to him)) : make haste and bring it out, there's a dear.

SCEPARNIO
Stay a moment; I'll be here this instant, my sweet one. ((Goes into the cottage.))

AMPELISCA
What shall I say to the Priestess for having delayed here so long a time? How, even still, in my wretchedness do I tremble, when with my eyes I look upon the sea. ((She looks towards the shore.))
But what, to my sorrow, do I see afar upon the shore? My master, the Procurer, and his Sicilian guest. both of whom wretched I supposed to have perished in the deep. Still does thus much more of evil survive for us than we had imagined. But why do I delay to run off into the Temple, and to tell
Palaestra this, that we may take refuge at the altar before this scoundrel of a Procurer can come hither and seize us here? I'll betake myself away from this spot; for the necessity suddenly arises for me to do so. ((Runs into the Temple.))

((Enter SCEPARNIO, from the cottage.))

SCEPARNIO
((to himself.))
O ye immortal Gods, I never did imagine that there was so great delight in water; how heartily I did draw this. The well seemed much less deep than formerly. How entirely without exertion did I draw this up. With all deference [37] to myself, am I not a very silly fellow,in having only to-day made a commencement of being in love [38] ? ((Turning slowly round, he holds out the pitcher.)) Here's the water for you, my pretty one; here now, I would have you carry it with as much pleasure as I carry it, that you may please me.
((Stares around him.)) But where are you, my tit-bit? Do take this water, please; where are you? ((Again looks about.)) I' troth, she's in love with me, as I fancy; the roguish one's playing bo-peep [39] . Where are you? Are you going now to take this pitcher? Where are you, I say? You've carried the joke far enough. Really, do be serious at last. Once more, are you going to take this pitcher? Where in the world are you?
((Looks about.)) I' troth, I don't see her anywhere, for my part; she's making fun of me. I' faith, I shall now set down this pitcher in the middle of the road. But yet, suppose any person should carry away from here this sacred pitcher of Venus, he would be causing me some trouble. I' faith, I'm afraid that this woman's laying a trap for me, that I may be caught with the sacred pitcher of Venus. In such case, with very good reason, the magistrate will be

letting me die in prison, if any one shall see me holding this. For it’s marked with the name; itself tells its own tale, whose property it is. Troth now, I’ll call that Priestess here out of doors,
that she may take this pitcher. I’ll go there to the door. ((He knocks.)) Hallo there! Ptolemocratia. ((Calling aloud.)) Take this pitcher of yours, please; some young woman, I don’t know who, brought it here to me. ((A pause.)) It must then be carried in-doors by me. I’ve found myself a job, if, in fact, of my own accord, water is to be carried by me for these people as well. ((Goes into the Temple with the pitcher.))

((Enter LABRAX, dripping wet, followed by CHARMIDES, at a distance, in the same plight.))

LABRAX
((grumbling to himself.))
The person that chooses himself to be wretched and a beggar, let him trust himself and his life to Neptune. For if any one has any dealings at all with him, he sends him back home equipped in this guise.
((Surveying himself.)) By my troth, Liberty, you were a clever one, who were never willing [40] to put even a foot, I’ faith, on board ship with me.
But ((looking round)) where’s this guest of mine that has proved my ruin? Oh, see, here he comes.

CHARMIDES
Where the plague are you hurrying to, Labrax? For really I cannot follow you so fast.

LABRAX
I only wish that you had perished by direful tornments in Sicily before I had looked upon you with my eyes,
you on whose account this misfortune has befallen me.

CHARMIDES
I only wish that on the day on which you admitted me into your house, I had laid me down in a prison sooner. I pray the immortal Gods, that so long as you live,
you may have all your guests just like your own self.

LABRAX
In your person I admitted misfortune into my house. What business had I to listen to a rogue like you, or what to depart hence? Or why to go on board ship, where I have lost even more wealth [41] than I was possessor of?

CHARMIDES
Troth, I’m far from being surprised if your ship has been wrecked, which was carrying yourself, a villain, and your property villanously acquired.

LABRAX
You’ve utterly ruined me with your wheedling speeches.

CHARMIDES
A more accursed dinner of yours have I been dining upon than the ones that were set before Thyestes and Tereus [42] .

LABRAX
I’m dying; I’m sick at heart. Prithee, do hold up my head.

CHARMIDES

By my troth, I could very much wish that you would vomit up your lungs.

LABRAX
Alas! Palaestra and Ampelisca, where are you now?

CHARMIDES
Supplying food for the fishes at the bottom, I suppose.

LABRAX
You have brought beggary upon me by your means,
while I was listening to your bragging lies.

CHARMIDES
You have reason deservedly to give me many hearty thanks, who from an insipid morsel by my agency have made you salt [43] .

LABRAX
Nay, but do you get out from me to extreme and utter perdition.

CHARMIDES
You be off; I was just going to do that very thing.

LABRAX
Alas! what mortal being is there living more wretched than I?

CHARMIDES
I am by very far much more wretched, Labrax, than yourself.

LABRAX
How so?

CHARMIDES
Because I am not deserving of it, whereas you are deserving.

LABRAX
O bulrush, bulrush, I do praise your lot, who always maintain your credit for dryness.

CHARMIDES
((his teeth chattering.))
For my part, I’m exercising myself for a skirmishing fight [44] , for, from my shivering, I utter all my words in piecemeal flashes.

LABRAX
By my troth, Neptune, you are a purveyor of chilly baths; since I got away from you with my clothes, I’ve been freezing.
No hot liquor-shop [45] at all for sure does he provide;
so salt and cold the potions that he prepares.

CHARMIDES
How lucky are the blacksmiths who are always sitting among hot coals; they are always warm.

LABRAX
I only wish that I were now enjoying the lot of the duck, so as, although I had just come from out of the water, still to be dry.

CHARMIDES
What if I some way or other let myself out at the games for a hobgoblin [46] ?

LABRAX
For what reason?

CHARMIDES
Because, I’ faith, I’m chattering aloud with my teeth.
But I’m of opinion that, with very good reason, I’ve had this ducking.

LABRAX
How so?

CHARMIDES
Why, haven’t I ventured to go on board ship with yourself, who have been stirring up the ocean for me from the very bottom?

LABRAX
I listened to you when advising me; you assured me that there in Sicily was very great profit from courtesans; there, you used to say, I should be able to amass wealth.

CHARMIDES
Did you expect, then, you unclean beast, that you were going to gobble up the whole island of Sicily?

LABRAX
What whale, I wonder, has gobbled up my wallet where all my gold and silver was packed up?

CHARMIDES
That same one, I suppose, that has swallowed my purse, which was full of silver in my travelling-bag.

LABRAX
Alas! I’m reduced even to this one poor tunic ((stretching it out))
and to this poor shabby cloak; I’m done for to all intents.

CHARMIDES
Then you may even go into partnership with me; we have got equal shares.

LABRAX
If at least my damsels had been saved, there would have been some hope. Now, if the young man Plesidippus should be seeing me,
from whom I received the earnest for Palaestra, he’ll then be causing me some trouble in consequence. ((He begins

to cry.))

CHARMIDES
Why cry, you fool? Really, by my troth, so long as your tongue shall exist, you have abundance with which to make payment to everybody [47] .

((Enter SCEPARNIO, from the Temple.))

SCEPARNIO
((to himself, aloud.))
What to-do is this, I'd like to know, that two young women
here in the Temple, in tears, are holding in their embrace the statue of Venus, dreading I know not what in their wretchedness? But they say that this last night they have been tossed about, and to-day cast on shore from the waves.

LABRAX
((overhearing.))
Troth now, young man, prithee, where are these young women that you are talking of?

SCEPARNIO
Here ((pointing)) in the Temple of Venus.

LABRAX
How many are there?

SCEPARNIO
Just as many as you and I make.

LABRAX
Surely, they are mine.

SCEPARNIO
Surely, I know nothing about that.

LABRAX
Of what appearance are they?

SCEPARNIO
Good-looking; I could even fall in love with either of them, if I were well liquored.

LABRAX
Surely, they are the damsels.

SCEPARNIO
Surely, you are a nuisance; be off, go in and see, if you like.

LABRAX
These must be my wenches in here, my dear Charmides.

CHARMIDES
Jupiter confound you, both if they are and still if they are not.

LABRAX
I'll straightway burst into this Temple of Venus here.

CHARMIDES
Into the bottomless pit, I would rather. ((LABRAX rushes into the Temple, and shuts the door.)) Prithee, stranger, show me some spot where I may go to sleep.

SCEPARNIO
Go to sleep there, wherever you please ((points to the ground)) ; no one hinders, it's free to the public.

CHARMIDES
((pointing to his clothes.))
But do you see me, in what wet clothes I'm dressed? Do take me under shelter; lend me some dry clothes, while my own are drying; on some occasion I'll return you the favour.

SCEPARNIO
See, here's my outer coat, which alone is dry; that, if you like, I'll lend you. ((Takes it off and holds it out to him.)) In that same I'm wont to be clothed, by that same protected, when it rains. Do you give me those clothes of yours; I'll soon have them dried.

CHARMIDES
How now, are you afraid that, as I've been washed bare [48] last night at sea, I mayn't be made bare again here upon shore?

SCEPARNIO
Wash you bare, or anoint you well, I don't care one fig [49] . I shall never entrust anything to you unless upon a pledge being taken. Do you either sweat away or perish with cold, be you either sick or well. I'll put up with no stranger-guest in my house; I've had disagreements enough. ((Puts on his coat again, and goes into the house of DAEMONES.))

CHARMIDES
What, are you off? ((A pause.)) He's a trafficker in slaves for money [50] ; whoever he is,
he has no bowels [51] of compassion. But why in my wretchedness am I standing here, soaking? Why don't I rather go away from here into the Temple of Venus, that I may sleep off this debauch which I got with drinking last night against the bent of my inclination? Neptune has been drenching us with salt water as though we were Greek wines [52] , and so he hoped that our stomachs might be vomited up with his salt draughts.
What need of words? If he had persisted in inviting us a little longer, we should have gone fast asleep there; as it is, hardly alive has he sent us off home. Now I'll go see the Procurer, my boon companion, what he's doing within. ((Goes into the Temple.))

((Enter DAEMONES, from his house.))

DAEMONES
((to himnself.))

In wondrous ways [53] do the Gods make sport of men, in wondrous fashions do they send dreams in sleep.
Not the sleeping, even, do they allow to rest. As, for example, I, this last night which has gone by, dreamed a wonderful and a curious dream. A she-ape seemed to be endeavouring to climb up to a swallow's nest;
and she was not able thence to take them out. After that, the ape seemed to come to me to beg me to lend a ladder to her. I in these terms gave answer to the ape, that swallows are the descendants of Philomela [54] and of Progne.
I expostulated with her, that she might not hurt those of my country. But then she began to be much more violent, and seemed gratuitously to be threatening me with vengeance. She summoned me to a court of justice. Then, in my anger, I seemed to seize hold of the ape by the middle, in what fashion I know not;
and I fastened up with chains this most worthless beast. Now to what purpose I shall say that this dream tends, never have I this day been able to come to any conclusion. ((A loud noise is heard in the Temple.)) But what's this noise that arises in this Temple of Venus, my neighbour? My mind's in wonder about it.

((Enter TRACHALIO, in haste, from the Temple.))

TRACHALIO
((aloud.))
O citizens of Cyrene, I implore your aid, countrymen, you who are near neighbours to these spots, bring aid to helplessness, and utterly crush a most vile attempt. Inflict vengeance, that the power of the wicked, who wish themselves to be distinguished by crimes, may not be stronger than of the guiltless.
Make an example for the shameless man, give its reward to modest virtue; cause that one may be allowed to live here rather under the control of the laws than of brute force. Hasten hither into the Temple of Venus; again do I implore your aid, you who are here at hand and who hear my cries.
Bring assistance to those who, after the recognized usage, have entrusted their lives to Venus and to the Priestess of Venus, under their protection.
Wring ye the neck of iniquity before it reaches yourselves.

DAEMONES
What's all this to-do?

TRACHALIO
((embracing his knees.))
By these knees of yours, I do entreat you, old gentleman, whoever you are—

DAEMONES
Nay, but do you let go my knees, then, and tell me why it is that you are making a noise?

TRACHALIO
I do beg and entreat you, that if you hope
this year that you will have abundance of laserwort and silphium [55] , and that that export will arrive at Capua [56] safe and sound, and that you may ever enjoy freedom from diseased eyes—

DAEMONES
Are you in your senses?

TRACHALIO
—Or whether you trust that you will have plenty of juice of silphium [57] , that you will not hesitate to give me the aid which I shall entreat of you, aged sir.

DAEMONES
And I, by your legs, and ancles, and back, do entreat you that, if you hope that you will have a crop of elm-twigs, and that a fruitful harvest of beatings will this year be your lot, you will tell me what's the matter here, by reason of which you are making this uproar.

TRACHALIO
Why do you choose to speak me ill? For my part, I wished you everything that's good.

DAEMONES
And for my part, I'm speaking you well, in praying that things which you deserve may befall you.

TRACHALIO
Prithee, do prevent this.

DAEMONES
What's the matter, then?

TRACHALIO
((pointing to the Temple.))
Two innocent women are inside here, in need of your aid, on whom, against law and justice, an injury has been, is being, glaringly committed here in the Temple of Venus. Besides, the Priestess of Venus
is being disgracefully insulted.

DAEMONES
What person is there of effrontery so great as to dare to injure the Priestess? But these women, who are they? Or what injury is being done to them?

TRACHALIO
If you give me your attention, I'll tell you. They have clung to the statue of Venus; a most audacious fellow is now trying to tear them away. They ought, by rights, both of them to be free.

DAEMONES
What fellow is it that so lightly holds the Gods? In a few words tell me.

TRACHALIO
One most full of fraud, villany, parricide, and perjury; a lawbreaker, an immodest, unclean, most shameless fellow; to sum up all in one word, he is a Procurer; why need I say more about him?

DAEMONES
Troth now, you tell of a man that ought to be handed over to retribution.

TRACHALIO
A villain, to seize the Priestess by the throat.

DAEMONES
By my troth, but he has done it at his own great peril. ((Calls aloud at his door.)) Come you out of doors here, Turbalio and Sparax; where are you?

TRACHALIO
Prithee, do go in, and hasten to their rescue.

DAEMONES
((impatiently.))
And am I to call for them once more? ((from the cottage.))

DAEMONES
Follow me this way. [58]

TRACHALIO
Come on now this instant, bid them tear his eyes out, just in the way that cooks do cuttle-fish [59] .

DAEMONES
Drag the fellow out here by his legs, just like a slaughtered pig. ((DAEMONES and his SERVANTS go into the Temple.))

TRACHALIO
((listening at the door.))
I hear a scuffling; the Procurer, I guess, is being belaboured with their fists; I'd very much like them to knock the teeth out of the jaws of the most villanous fellow. But see, here are the women themselves coming out of the Temple in consternation.

((Enter PALAESTRA and AMPELISCA, in haste, from the Temple, with dishevelled locks.))

PALAESTRA
Now is that time arrived when destitution of all resources and aid,
succour and defence, overtakes us. Neither hope nor means is there to bring us aid, nor know we in what direction we should commence to proceed. In exceeding terror now are we both, in this our wretchedness. Such cruelty and such outrage
have been committed towards us just now in-doors here by our master, who, in his villany, pushed down the old lady, the Priestess, headlong, and struck her in a very disgraceful manner, and with his violence tore us away from the inner side [60] of the statue. But as our lot and fortunes are now showing themselves,
'twere best to die, nor in our miseries is there anything better than death.

TRACHALIO
((behind.))
What's this? Whose words are those? Why do I delay to console them? ((Aloud.)) Harkye, Palaestra, Ampelisca, harkye!

PALAESTRA
Prithee, who is it that calls us?

AMPELISCA
Who is it that calls me by name?

TRACHALIO
If you turn round and look, you'll know.

PALAESTRA
((turning round.))
O hope of my safety!

TRACHALIO
Be silent and of good courage; trust me [61] .

PALAESTRA
If only it can be so, let not violence overwhelm us.

TRACHALIO
What violence?

PALAESTRA
That same which is driving me to commit violence on myself.

TRACHALIO
Oh, do leave off; you are very silly.

PALAESTRA
Then do you leave off at once your consoling me in my misery with words.

AMPELISCA
Unless you afford us protection in reality [62] , Trachalio, it’s all over with us.

PALAESTRA
I’m resolved to die sooner than suffer this Procurer to get me in his power. But still I am of woman’s heart; when, in my misery, death comes into my mind, fear takes possession of my limbs. [63]

TRACHALIO
By my troth, although this is a bitter affliction,
do have a good heart.

PALAESTRA
Why where, pray, is a good heart to be found for me?

TRACHALIO
Don’t you fear, I tell you; sit you down here by the altar. ((Points to it.))

AMPELISCA
What can this altar possibly avail us more than the statue here within the Temple
of Venus, from which just now, embracing it, in our wretchedness, we were torn by force?

TRACHALIO
Only you be seated here; then I’ll protect you in this spot. This altar you possess as though your bulwarks [64] ; these your fortifications; from this spot will I defend you. With the aid of Venus, I’ll march against the wickedness of the Procurer.

PALAESTRA
We follow your instructions ((they advance to the altar and kneel)) ; and genial Venus, we both of us, in tears, implore thee,
embracing this thy altar, bending upon our knees, that thou wilt receive us into thy guardianship, and be our protector; that thou wilt punish those wretches who have set at nought thy Temple, and that thou wilt suffer us to occupy this thy altar with thy permission, we who last night were by the might of Neptune cast away;
hold us not in scorn, and do not for that reason impute it to us as a fault, if there is anything that thou shouldst think is not so well attended to [65] by us as it ought to have been.

TRACHALIO
I think they ask what's just; it ought, Venus, by thee to be granted. Thou oughtst to pardon them; 'tis terror forces them to do this. They say that thou wast born from a shell [66] ; take thou care that thou dost not despise the shells of these.
But see, most opportunely the old gentleman is coming out, both my protector and your own. ((He goes to the altar.))

((Enter DAEMONES, from the Temple, with his two SERVANTS dragging out LABRAX.))

DAEMONES
Come out of the Temple, you most sacrilegious of men, as many as have ever been born. Do you go ((calling to the WOMEN)) and sit by the altar. ((Not seeing them near the door.)) But where are they?

TRACHALIO
Look round here.

DAEMONES
((looking round.))
Very good; I wanted that [67] . Now bid him come this way. ((To LABRAX.)) Are you attempting here among us to commit a violation of the laws against the Deities?
((To the SERVANTS, who obey with alacrity.)) Punch his face with your fists.

LABRAX
I'm suffering these indignities at your own cost.

DAEMONES
Why, the insolent fellow's threatening even.

LABRAX
I've been robbed of my rights; you are robbing me of my female slaves against my will.

TRACHALIO
Do you then find some wealthy man of the Senate of Cyrene as judge, whether these women ought to be yours, or whether they oughtn't to be free,
or whether it isn't right that you should be clapped into prison, and there spend your life, until you have worn the whole gaol out with your feet.

LABRAX

I wasn’t prepared to prophesy for this day that I should be talking with a hang-gallows [68] like yourself.
((Turning to DAEMONES.)) You do I summon to judgment.

DAEMONES
((pointing to TRACHALIO.))
In the first place, try it with him who knows you.

LABRAX
((to DAEMONES.))
My suit is with yourself.

TRACHALIO
But it must be with myself. ((Pointing to the WOMEN.)) Are these your female slaves?

LABRAX
They are.

TRACHALIO
Just come then, touch either of them with your little finger only.

LABRAX
What if I do touch them?

TRACHALIO
That very instant, upon my faith, I’ll make a hand-ball [69] of you, and while you’re in the air I’ll belabour you with my fists, you most perjured villain.

LABRAX
Am I not to be allowed to take away my female slaves from the altar of Venus?

DAEMONES
You may not; such is the law with us.

LABRAX
I’ve no concern with your laws; for my part, I shall at once carry them both away from here [70] .
If you are in love with them, old gentleman ((holding out his hand)) , you must down here with the ready cash.

DAEMONES
But these women have proved pleasing to Venus.

LABRAX
She may have them, if she pays the money. [71]

DAEMONES
A Goddess, pay you money? Now then, that you may understand my determination, only do you commence in mere joke to offer them the very slightest violence;
I’ll send you away from here with such a dressing, that you won’t know your own self. You, therefore ((turning to his SERVANTS)) , when I give you the signal, if you don’t beat his eyes out of his head, I’ll trim you round about

with rods just like beds of myrtle [72] with bulrushes.

LABRAX
You are treating me with violence.

TRACHALIO
What, do you even upbraid us with violence, you flagrant specimen of flagitiousness?

LABRAX
You, you thrice-dotted villain [73] , do you dare to speak abusively to me?

TRACHALIO
I am a thrice-dotted villain; I confess it; you are a strictly honorable man; ought these women a bit the less to be free?

LABRAX
What—free?

TRACHALIO
Aye, and your mistresses, too, I' faith, and from genuine Greece [74] ; for one of them was born at Athens of free-born parents.

DAEMONES
What is it I hear from you?

TRACHALIO
That she ((pointing to PALAESTRA)) was born at Athens, a free-born woman.

DAEMONES
((to TRACHALIO.))
Prithee is she a countrywoman of mine?

TRACHALIO
Are you not a Cyrenian?

DAEMONES
No; born at Athens in Attica, bred and educated there.

TRACHALIO
Prithee, aged sir, do protect your countrywomen.

DAEMONES
((aside.))
O daughter, when I look on her, separated from me you remind me of my miseries: ((aloud)) she who was lost by me when three years old; now, if she is living, she's just about as tall, I'm sure, as she. ((Pointing to PALAESTRA.))

LABRAX

I paid the money down for these two, to their owners, of whatever country they were. What matters it to me whether they were born at Athens or at Thebes, so long as they are rightfully in servitude as my slaves?

TRACHALIO
Is it so, you impudent fellow? What, are you, a cat prowling after maidens, to be keeping children here kidnapped from their parents and destroying them in your disgraceful calling?
But as for this other one, I really don't know what her country is; I only know that she's more deserving than yourself, you most abominable rascal.

LABRAX
Are these women your property?

TRACHALIO
Come to the trial, then, which of the two according to his back is the more truthful; if you don't bear more compliments [75] upon your back than any ship of war [76] has nails, then I'm the greatest of liars.
Afterwards, do you examine mine, when I've examined yours; if it shall not prove to be so untouched, that any leather flask maker [77] will say that it is a hide most capital and most sound for the purposes of his business, what reason is there why I shouldn't mangle you with stripes, even till you have your belly full? Why do you stare at them? If you touch them I'll tear your eyes out.

LABRAX
Yet notwithstanding, although you forbid me to do so, I'll at once carry them off both together with me.

DAEMONES
What will you do?

LABRAX
I'll bring Vulcan; he is an enemy to Venus [78] . ((Goes towards DAEMONES' cottage.))

TRACHALIO
Whither is he going?

LABRAX
((calling at the door.))
Hallo! Is there anybody here? Hallo! I say.

DAEMONES
If you touch the door, that very instant, upon my faith, you shall get a harvest upon your face with fists for your pitchforks [79] .

SERVANT
We keep no fire, we live upon dried figs.

DAEMONES
I'll find the fire, if only I have the opportunity of kindling it upon your head.

LABRAX
Faith, I'll go somewhere to look for some fire.

DAEMONES
What, when you've found it?

LABRAX
I'll be making a great fire here.

DAEMONES
What, to be burning [80] a mortuary sacrifice for yourself?

LABRAX
No, but I'll burn both of these alive here upon the altar.

DAEMONES
I'd like that. For, by my troth, I'll forthwith seize you by the head and throw you into the fire,
and, half-roasted, I'll throw you out as food for the great birds. ((Aside.)) When I come to a consideration of it with myself, this is that ape, that wanted to take away those swallows from the nest against my will, as I was dreaming in my sleep.

TRACHALIO
Aged sir, do you know what I request of you? That you will protect these females and defend them from violence, until I fetch my master.

DAEMONES
Go look for your master, and fetch him here.

TRACHALIO
But don't let him—

DAEMONES
At his own extreme peril, if he touches them, or if he attempts to do so.

TRACHALIO
Take care.

DAEMONES
Due care is taken; do you be off.

TRACHALIO
And watch him too, that he doesn't go away anywhere. For we have promised either to give the executioner a great talent, or else to produce this fellow this very day.

DAEMONES
Do you only be off. I'll not let him get away, while you are absent.

TRACHALIO
I'll be back here soon. ((Exit TRACHALIO.))

((DAEMONES, LABRAX, PALAESTRA, AMPELISCA, and SERVANTS.))

DAEMONES
((to LABRAX, who is struggling with the SERVANTS.))
Which, you Procurer, had you rather do, be quiet with a thrashing, or e’en as it is, without the thrashing, if you had the choice?

LABRAX
Old fellow, I don’t care a straw for what you say. My own women, in fact, I shall drag away this instant from the altar by the hair, in spite of yourself, and Venus, and supreme Jove.

DAEMONES
Just touch them.

LABRAX
((going towards them))
I’ troth, I surely will touch them.

DAEMONES
Just come then; only approach this way.

LABRAX
Only bid both those fellows, then, to move away from there.

DAEMONES
On the contrary, they shall move towards you.

LABRAX
I’ faith, for my own part, I don’t think so.

DAEMONES
If they do move nearer to you, what will you do?

LABRAX
I’ll retire. But, old fellow, if ever I catch you in the city,
never again, upon my faith, shall any one call me a Procurer, if I don’t give you some most disagreable sport.

DAEMONES
Do what you threaten. But now, in the meantime, if you do touch them, a heavy punishment shall be inflicted on you.

LABRAX
How heavy, in fact?

DAEMONES
Just as much as is sufficient for a Procurer.

LABRAX

These threats of yours I don’t value one straw; I certainly shall seize them both this instant without your leave.

DAEMONES
Just touch them.

LABRAX
By my troth, I surely will touch them.

DAEMONES
You will touch them, but do you know with what result? Go then, Turbalio, with all haste, and bring hither from out of the house two cudgels.

LABRAX
Cudgels?

DAEMONES
Aye, good ones; make haste speedily. ((TURBALIO goes in.))
I’ll let you have a reception this day in proper style, as you are deserving of.

LABRAX
((aside.))
Alas! cursedly unfortunate. I lost my headpiece in the ship; it would now have been handy for me, if it had been saved. ((To DAEMONES.)) May I at least address these women?

DAEMONES
You may not
((TURBALIO enters bringing two cudgels.)) Well now, by my faith, look, the cudgel-man is coming very opportunely here.

LABRAX
((aside.))
By my troth, this surely is a tingling for my ears.

DAEMONES
Come, Sparax, do you take this other cudgel. ((Giving him one.)) Come, take your stand, one on one side, the other on one other. Take your stations both of you. ((They stand with lifted cudgels on each side of he altar.)) Just so. Now then attend to me:
if, I’ faith, that fellow there should this day touch these women with his finger against their inclination, if you don’t give him a reception [81] with these cudgels even to that degree that he shan’t know which way he is to get home, you are undone, both of you. If he shall call for any one, do you make answer to this fellow in their stead. But if he himself shall attempt to get away from here, that instant, as hard a you can, lay on to his legs with your sticks.

LABRAX
Are they not even to allow me to go away from here?

DAEMONES
I’ve said sufficient. And when that servant comes here with his master, he that has gone to fetch his master, do you

at once go home.
Attend to this with great diligence, will you. ((DAEMONES goes into his house.))

LABRAX
O rare, by my troth, the Temple here is surely changed all of a sudden; this is now the Temple of Hercules [82] which was that of Venus before; in such fashion has the old fellow planted two statues here with clubs. I' faith, I don't know now whither in the world I shall fly from here;
so greatly are they both raging now against me, both land and sea. Palaestra!

SERVANT
What do you want?

LABRAX
Away with you, there is a misunderstanding between us; that, indeed, is not my Palaestra [83] that answers. Harkye, Ampelisca.

SERVANT
Beware of a mishap, will you.

LABRAX
((aside.))
So far as they can, the worthless fellows advise me rightly enough.
((Aloud.)) But, harkye, I ask you, whether it is any harm to you for me to come nearer to these women?

SERVANT
Why none at all to ourselves.

LABRAX
Will there be any harm to myself?

SERVANT
None at all, if you only take care.

LABRAX
What is it that I'm to take care against?

SERVANT
Why, look you, against a heavy mishap.

LABRAX
Troth now, prithee, do let me approach them.

SERVANT
Approach them, if you like.

LABRAX
I' faith, obligingly done; I return you thanks, I'll go nearer to them. ((Approaches them.))

SERVANT
Do you stand there on the spot, where you are. ((Drags him to his place, with the cudgel over his head.))

LABRAX
((aside.))
By my faith, I've come scurvily off in many ways. Still, I'm resolved to get the better of them this day by constantly besieging them.

((Enter PLESIDIPPUS and TRACHALIO, at a distance, on the other side of the stage.))

PLESIDIPPUS
And did the Procurer attempt by force and violence
to drag my mistress away from the altar of Venus?

TRACHALIO
Even so.

PLESIDIPPUS
Why didn't you kill him on the instant?

TRACHALIO
I hadn't a sword.

PLESIDIPPUS
You should have taken either a stick or a stone.

TRACHALIO
What! ought I to have pelted this most villanous fellow with stones like a dog?

LABRAX
((aside, on seeing them.))
By my troth, but I'm undone now; see, here's Plesidippus;
he'll be sweeping me away altogether this moment with the dust.

PLESIDIPPUS
Were the damsels sitting on the altar even then when you set out to come to me?

TRACHALIO
Yes, and now they are sitting in the same place.

PLESIDIPPUS
Who is now protecting them there?

TRACHALIO
Some old gentleman, I don't know who, a neighbour of the Temple of Venus—he gave very kind assistance; he is now protecting them with his servants—I committed them to his charge.

PLESIDIPPUS

Lead me straight to the Procurer. Where is this fellow? ((They go towards LABRAX.))

LABRAX
Health to you.

PLESIDIPPUS
I want none of your healths. Make your choice quickly, whether you lad rather be seized by your throat wrenched [84] , or be dragged along; choose whichever you please, while you may.

LABRAX
I wish for neither.

PLESIDIPPUS
Be off then, Trachalio, with all speed to the sea-shore; bid those persons that I brought with me to hand over this rascal to the executioner, to come from the harbour to the city to meet me; afterwards return hither and keep guard here. I'll now drag this scoundrelly outcast to justice. ((Exit TRACHALIO. Pleusicles addresses LABRAX.)) Come, proceed to a court of justice.

LABRAX
In what have I offended?

PLESIDIPPUS
Do you ask? Didn't you receive an earnest of me for this woman ((pointing to PALAESTRA)) , and carry her off from here?

LABRAX
I didn't carry her off.

PLESIDIPPUS
Why do you deny it?

LABRAX
Troth now, because I put her on board ship; carry her off [85] unfortunately, I couldn't. For my part, I told you that this day I would make my appearance
at the Temple of Venus; have I swerved at all from that? Am I not there?

PLESIDIPPUS
Plead your cause in the court of justice; here a word is enough. Follow me. ((They lay hold of him.))

LABRAX
((calling aloud.))
I entreat you, my dear Charmides, do come to my rescue; I am being seized with my throat wrenched. ((Enter CHARMIDES, from the Temple.))

CHARMIDES
((looking about.))
Who calls my name?

LABRAX
Do you see me how I’m being seized?

CHARMIDES
I see, and view it with pleasure.

LABRAX
Don’t you venture to assist me?

CHARMIDES
What person is seizing you?

LABRAX
Young Plesidippus.

CHARMIDES
What you’ve got, put up with; ’twere better for you, with a cheerful spirit, to slink to gaol; that has befallen you which many greatly wish for for themselves.

LABRAX
What’s that?

CHARMIDES
To find for themselves that which they are seeking.

LABRAX
I entreat you, do follow me.

CHARMIDES
You try to persuade me, just like what you are: you are being taken off to gaol, for that reason is it you entreat me to follow you?

PLESIDIPPUS
((to LABRAX.))
Do you still resist?

LABRAX
I’m undone.

PLESIDIPPUS
I trust that may prove the truth. You, my dear Palaestra and Ampelisca, do you remain here in the meanwhile, until I return hither.

SERVANT
I would advise them
rather to go to our house, until you return.

PLESIDIPPUS

I’m quite agreable; you act obligingly. ((The SERVANTS open the door of the cottage, and PALAESTRA and AMPELISCA go in.))

LABRAX
You are thieves to me.

SERVANT
How, thieves?

PLESIDIPPUS
Lead him along. [86] ((The SERVANTS seize him.))

LABRAX
((calling out.))
I pray and entreat you, Palaestra.

PLESIDIPPUS
Follow, you hang-dog.

LABRAX
Guest, Charmides!

CHARMIDES
I am no guest of yours; I repudiate your hospitality.

LABRAX
What, do you slight me in this fashion?

CHARMIDES
I do so; I’ve been drinking with you once already [87] .

LABRAX
May the Deities confound you.

CHARMIDES
To that person of yours, say that. ((PLESIDIPPUS leads LABRAX off, followed by the SERVANTS.)) I do believe that men are transformed, each into a different beast. That Procurer, I guess, is transformed into a stock-dove [88] ; for, before long, his neck will be in the stocks. He’ll to-day be building his nest in the gaol.
Still, however, I’ll go, that I may be his advocate,—if by my aid he may possibly be sentenced any the sooner.

((Enter DAEMONES, from his cottage. [89])

DAEMONES
((to himself.))
’Twas rightly done, and it is a pleasure this day for me to have given aid to these young women; I have now found some dependants, and both of them of comely looks and youthful age.
But my plaguy wife is watching me in all ways, lest I should be giving any hint to the young women. But I wonder what in the world my servant Gripus is about, who went last night to the sea to fish. Troth, he had done wiser if he

had slept at home;
for now he throws away both his pains and his nets, seeing what a storm there now is and was last night. I'll thoroughly cook upon my fingers what he has caught to-day; so violently do I see the ocean heaving. ((A bell rings.)) But my wife's calling me to breakfast; I'll return home.
She'll now be filling my ears with her silly prating. ((Goes into the cottage.))

((Enter GRIPUS, dragging a net enclosing a wallet, by a rope.))

GRIPUS
((to himself.))
These thanks do I return to Neptune, my patron, who dwells in the salt retreats, the abode of fishes, inasmuch as he has despatched me finely laden on my return from his retreats, and from his Temples, laden with most abundant booty,
with safety to my boat, which in the stormy sea made me master of a singular and rich haul. In a wondrous and incredible manner has this haul turned out prosperously for me, nor yet have I this day taken a single ounce weight of fish, but only that which I am here bringing with me in my net.
For when I arose in the middle of the night, and without sloth, I preferred profit to sleep and rest; in the raging tempest, I determined to try how I might lighten the poverty of my master and my own servitude, not sparing of my own exertions.
Most worthless is the man that is slothful, and most detestably do I hate that kind of men. It behoves him to be vigilant who wishes to do his duty in good time; for it befits him not to be waiting until his master arouses him to his duties. For those who sleep on for the love of it, rest without profit to themselves and to their own cost.
But now I, who have not been slothful, have found that for myself through which to be slothful if I should choose. ((Points to the wallet.)) This have I found in the sea to-day; whatever's in it, it's something heavy that's in it; I think it's gold that's in it. And not a single person is there my confidant in the matter. Now, Gripus, this opportunity has befallen you, that the Praetor [90] might make you a free man from among the multitude. Now, thus shall I do, this is my determination; I'll come to my master cleverly and cunningly, little by little I'll promise money for my freedom, that I may be free.
Now, when I shall be free, then, in fine, I'll provide me land and houses [91] and slaves: I'll carry on merchandize with large ships: among the grandees I shall be considered a grandee. Afterwards, for the sake of pleasing myself, I'll build me a ship and I'll imitate Stratonicus [92] , and I'll be carried about from town to town. When my greatness is far-spread, I shall fortify some great city: to that city I shall give the name of Gripus,
a memorial of my fame and exploits, and there I'll establish a mighty kingdom. I am resolving here in my mind to prepare for mighty matters. At present I'll hide this booty. But this grandee ((pointing to himself)) is about to breakfast upon vinegar [93] and salt, without any good substantial meat. ((Gathers up the net, and drags it after him.))

((Enter TRACHALIO, in haste.))

TRACHALIO
Hallo there! stop.

GRIPUS
Why should I stop?

TRACHALIO
While I coil up this rope [94] for you that you are dragging.

GRIPUS
Now let it alone.

TRACHALIO
Troth, but I'll assist you. What's kindly done to worthy men, isn't thrown away.

GRIPUS
There was a boisterous tempest yesterday; no fish have I, young man; don't you be supposing I have. Don't you see that I'm carrying my dripping net without the scaly race?

TRACHALIO
I' faith, I'm not wishing for fish so much as I am in need of your conversation.

GRIPUS
Then, whoever you are, you are worrying me to death with your annoyance.

TRACHALIO
((takes hold of him.))
I'll not allow you to go away from here; stop.

GRIPUS
Take you care of a mishap, if you please; but why the plague are you dragging me back?

TRACHALIO
Listen.

GRIPUS
I won't listen.

TRACHALIO
But, upon my faith, you shall listen.

GRIPUS
Nay but, another time, tell me what you want.

TRACHALIO
Come now, it's worth your while at once to hear what I want to tell you.

GRIPUS
Say on, whatever it is.

TRACHALIO
See whether any person is following near us. ((Looks back.))

GRIPUS
Why, what reason is there that it should matter to me?

TRACHALIO

So it is;
but can you give me some good advice?

GRIPUS
What's the business? Only tell me.

TRACHALIO
I'll tell you; keep silence; if only you'll give me your word that you won't prove treacherous to me.

GRIPUS
I do give you my word; I'll be true to you, whoever you are.

TRACHALIO
Listen. I saw a person commit a theft;
I knew the owner to whom that same property belonged. Afterwards I came myself to the thief, and I made him a proposal in these terms: I know the person on whom that theft was committed; now if you are ready to give me half, I'll not make a discovery to the owner.
He didn't even give me an answer. What is it fair should be given me out of it? Half, I trust you will say.

GRIPUS
Aye, even more; but unless he gives it you, I think it ought to be told to the owner.

TRACHALIO
I'll act on your advice. Now give me your attention; for it is to yourself all this relates.

GRIPUS
What has been done by me?

TRACHALIO
((pointing at the wallet.))
I've known the person for a long time to whom that wallet belongs.

GRIPUS
What do you mean?

TRACHALIO
And in what manner it was lost.

GRIPUS
But I know in what manner it was found;
and I know the person who found it, and who is now the owner. That, I' faith, is not a bit the more your matter than it is my own. I know the person to whom it now belongs; you, the person to whom it formerly belonged. This shall no individual get away from me; don't you be expecting to get it in a hurry.

TRACHALIO
If the owner comes, shan't he get it away?

GRIPUS

That you mayn’t be mistaken, no born person is there that’s owner of this but my own self—who took this in my own fishing.

TRACHALIO
Was it really so?

GRIPUS
Which fish in the sea will you say is my own? When I catch them, if indeed I do catch them, they are my own; as my own I keep them. They are not claimed as having a right to freedom [95] nor does any person demand a share in them. In the market I sell them all openly as my own wares.
Indeed, the sea is, surely, common to all persons.

TRACHALIO
I agree to that; prithee, then, why any the less is it proper that this wallet should be common to me? It was found in the sea.

GRIPUS
Assuredly you are an outrageously impudent fellow; for if this is justice which you are saying, then fishermen would be ruined. Inasmuch as, the moment that the fish were exposed upon the stalls,
no one would buy them; every person would be demanding his own share of the fish for himself; he would be saying that they were caught in the sea that was common to all.

TRACHALIO
What do you say, you impudent fellow? Do you dare to compare a wallet with fish? Pray, does it appear to be the same thing?

GRIPUS
The matter doesn’t lie in my power; when I’ve cast my hook and net into the sea, whatever has adhered I draw out. Whatever my net and hooks have got, that in especial is my own.

TRACHALIO
Nay but, I’ faith, it is not; if, indeed, you’ve fished up any article that’s made [96]

GRIPUS
Philosopher, you.

TRACHALIO
But look now, you conjurer, did you ever see a fisherman who caught a wallet-fish, or exposed one for sale in the market? But, indeed, you shan’t here be taking possession of all the profits that you choose;
you expect, you dirty fellow, to be both a maker of wallets [97] and a fisherman. Either you must show me a fish that is a wallet, or else you shall carry nothing off that wasn’t produced in the sea and has no scales.

GRIPUS
What, did you never hear before to-day that a wallet was a fish?

TRACHALIO
Villain, there is no such fish.

GRIPUS
Yes, there certainly is; I, who am a fisherman, know it.
But it is seldom caught; no fish more rarely comes near the land.

TRACHALIO
It’s to no purpose; you hope that you can be cheating me, you rogue. Of what colour is it?

GRIPUS
((looking at the wallet.))
Of this colour very few are caught: some are of a purple skin, there are great and black ones also.

TRACHALIO
I understand; by my troth, you’ll be turning into a wallet-fish I fancy, if you don’t take care;
your skin will be purple, and then afterwards black.

GRIPUS
((aside.))
What a villain this that I have met with to-day!

TRACHALIO
We are wasting words; the day wears apace. Consider, please, by whose arbitration do you wish us to proceed?

GRIPUS
By the arbitration of the wallet.

TRACHALIO
Really so, indeed? You are a fool.

GRIPUS
My respects to you, Mister Thales [98] ((Going.))

TRACHALIO
((holding him.))
You shan’t carry that off this day, unless you find a place of safe keeping for it, or an umpire,
by whose arbitration this matter may be settled.

GRIPUS
Prithee, are you in your senses?

TRACHALIO
I’m mad, in need of hellebore.

GRIPUS
But I’m troubled with sprites; still I shan’t let this go. ((Hugs the wallet.))

TRACHALIO
Only add a single word more, that instant I’ll drive my fists smash into your brains. This instant on this spot, just as a new napkin is wont to be wrung, I’ll wring out of you whatever moisture there is, if you don’t let this go.

((Seizes the wallet.))

GRIPUS
Touch me; I'll dash you down on the ground just in such fashion as I'm in the habit of doing with a polypus fish [99] . Would you like to fight? ((Assumes a boxing attitude.))

TRACHALIO
What need is there? Nay, in preference, divide the booty.

GRIPUS
You can't get anything from here but harm to yourself, so don't expect it. I'm taking myself off.

TRACHALIO
But I'll turn aside your ship from that direction, that you mayn't be off anywhere—stop. ((Stands in front of him, and holds the rope.))

GRIPUS
If you are the helmsman of this ship, I'll be the pilot.
Let go of the rope now, you villain.

TRACHALIO
I will let go; do you let go of the wallet.

GRIPUS
I' faith, you shall never this day become a scrap the more wealthy from this.

TRACHALIO
You cannot convince me by repeatedly denying, unless either a part is given me, or it is referred to arbitration, or it is placed in safe keeping.

GRIPUS
What, that which I got out of the sea—?

TRACHALIO
But I spied it out from the shore.

GRIPUS
—With my own pains and labour, and net and boat.

TRACHALIO
If now the owner, whose property it is, were to come, how am I, who espied from afar that you had taken this, a bit the less the thief than yourself?

GRIPUS
None whatever. ((Going.))

TRACHALIO
((seizing the net.))

Stop, you whip-knave; just let me learn of you by what reasoning I am not the sharer, and yet the thief.

GRIPUS
I don’t know; neither do I know these city laws of yours,
only that I affirm that this is mine. ((Looks at the wallet.))

TRACHALIO
And I, too, say that it is mine.

GRIPUS
Stay now; I’ve discovered by what method you may be neither thief nor sharer.

TRACHALIO
By what method?

GRIPUS
Let me go away from here; you quietly go your own way, and don’t you inform against me to any one, and I won’t give anything to you. You hold your tongue; I’ll be mum. This is the best and the fairest plan.

TRACHALIO
Well, what proposition do you venture to make?

GRIPUS
I’ve made it already; for you to go away, to let go of the rope, and not to be a nuisance to me.

TRACHALIO
Stop while I propose terms.

GRIPUS
I’ faith, do, prithee, dispose [100] of yourself forthwith.

TRACHALIO
Do you know any one in these parts?

GRIPUS
My own neighbours I must know.

TRACHALIO
Where do you live here?

GRIPUS
((pointing.))
At a distance out away yonder, as far off as the farthest fields.

TRACHALIO
((pointing to the cottage of DAEMONES.))
The person that lives in that cottage, should you like it to be decided by his arbitration?

GRIPUS
Let go of the rope for a moment while I step aside and consider.

TRACHALIO
Be it so. ((Lets go of the rope.))

GRIPUS
((aside.))
Capital, the thing's all right; the whole of this booty is my own. He's inviting me here inside of my own abode to my own master as umpire. By my troth, he never this day will award three obols away from his own servant. Assuredly, this fellow doesn't know what proposal he has been making. ((To TRACHALIO.)) I'll go to the arbitrator with you.

TRACHALIO
What then?

GRIPUS
Although I know for sure that this is my own lawful right, let that be done rather than I should now be fighting with you.

TRACHALIO
Now you satisfy me.

GRIPUS
Although you are driving me before an arbitrator whom I don't know, if he shall administer justice, although he is unknown, he is as good as known to me; if he doesn't, though known, he is the same as though entirely unknown.

((Enter DAEMONES, from his cottage, with PALAESTRA and AMPELISCA, and SERVANTS.))

DAEMONES
((to the WOMEN.))
Seriously, upon my faith, young women, although I wish what you desire, I'm afraid that on your account my wife will be turning me out of doors, who'll be saying that I've brought harlots here before her very eyes. Do you take refuge at the altar rather than I [101] .

THE WOMEN
We, wretched creatures, are undone. ((They weep.))

DAEMONES
I'll place you in safety; don't you fear. But why ((turning to the SERVANTS)) are you following me out of doors? Since I'm here, no one shall do them harm.
Now then, be off, I say, in-doors, both of you, you guards from off guard. ((They go in.))

GRIPUS
O master, save you.

DAEMONES
Save you. How goes it?

TRACHALIO
((pointing to GRIPUS.))
Is he your servant?

GRIPUS
I’m not ashamed to say yes.

TRACHALIO
I’ve nothing to do with you.

GRIPUS
Then get you gone hence, will you.

TRACHALIO
Prithee, do answer me, aged sir; is he your servant?

DAEMONES
He is mine.

TRACHALIO
Oh then, that is very good, since he is yours.
Again I salute you.

DAEMONES
And I you. Are you he who, not long since, went away from here to fetch his master?

TRACHALIO
I am he.

DAEMONES
What now is it that you want?

TRACHALIO
((pointing to GRIPUS.))
This is your servant, you say?

DAEMONES
He is mine.

TRACHALIO
That is very good, since he is yours.

DAEMONES
What’s the matter?

TRACHALIO
((pointing to GRIPUS.))

That’s a rascally fellow there.

DAEMONES
What has the rascally fellow done to you?

TRACHALIO
I wish the ancles of that fellow were smashed.

DAEMONES
What’s the thing about which you are now disputing between yourselves?

TRACHALIO
I’ll tell you.

GRIPUS
No, I’ll tell you.

TRACHALIO
I fancy I’m to move the matter first.

GRIPUS
If indeed you were a decent person, you would be moving yourself off from here.

DAEMONES
Gripus, give attention, and hold your tongue

GRIPUS
In order that that fellow may speak first?

DAEMONES
Attend, Itell you. ((To TRACHALIO.)) Do you say on.

GRIPUS
Will you give the right of speaking to a stranger sooner than to your own servant?

TRACHALIO
O dear! how impossible it is for him to be kept quiet.
As I was beginning to say, that Procurer, whom some little time since you turned out of the Temple of Venus—see ((pointing at the wallet)) , he has got his wallet.

GRIPUS
I haven’t got it.

TRACHALIO
Do you deny that which I see with my own eyes?

GRIPUS
But I only wish you couldn’t see. I have got it, and I haven’t got it; why do you trouble yourself about me, what

things I do?

TRACHALIO
In what way you got it does matter, whether rightfully or wrongfully.

GRIPUS
If I didn’t take it in the sea, there’s not a reason why you shouldn’t deliver me up to the cross. If I took it in the sea with my net, how is it yours rather than my own?

TRACHALIO
((to DAEMONES.))
He is deceiving you; the matter happened in this way, as I am telling you.

GRIPUS
What do you say?

TRACHALIO
So long as the person that has the first right to speak is speaking, do ((to DAEMONES)) put a check on him, please, if he belongs to you.

GRIPUS
What, do you wish the same thing to be done to myself, that your master has been accustomed to do to yourself? If he is in the habit of putting a check upon you, this master of ours isn’t in the habit of doing so with us.

DAEMONES
((to TRACUALIO.))
In that remark only has he got the better [102] of you. What do you want now? Tell me.

TRACHALIO
For my part, I neither ask for a share of that wallet there, nor have I ever said this day that it is my own; but in it there is a little casket that belongs to this female ((pointing to PALAESTRA)) , whom a short time since I averred to be free born.

DAEMONES
You are speaking of her, I suppose, whom a short time since you said was my countrywoman?

TRACHALIO
Just so; and those trinkets which formerly, when little, she used to wear, are there in that casket, which is in that wallet. This thing is of no service to him, and will be of utility to her, poor creature, if he gives it up, by means of which to seek for her parents.

DAEMONES
I’ll make him give it up; hold your tongue.

GRIPUS
I’ faith, I’m going to give nothing to that fellow.

TRACHALIO

I ask for nothing but the casket and the trinkets [103] .

GRIPUS
What if they are made of gold?

TRACHALIO
What's that to you? Gold shall be paid for gold, silver shall have its weight in silver in return.

GRIPUS
Please let me see the gold; after that I'll let you see the casket.

DAEMONES
((to GRIPUS.))
Do you beware of punishment, and hold your tongue. ((To TRACHALIO.)) As you commenced to speak do you go on.

TRACHALIO
This one thing I entreat of you, that you will have compassion on this female, if, indeed, this wallet is that Procurer's, which I suspect it is. In this matter, I'm saying nothing of certainty to you, but only on conjecture.

GRIPUS
Do you see how the rascal's wheedling him?

TRACHALIO
Allow me to say on as I commenced. If this is the wallet that belongs to that villain whose I say it is, these women here will be able to recognize it; order him to show it to them.

GRIPUS
Say you so? To show it to them?

DAEMONES
He doesn't say unreasonably, Gripus, that the wallet should be shown.

GRIPUS
Yes, I' faith, confoundedly unreasonably.

DAEMONES
How so?

GRIPUS
Because, if I do show it, at once they'll say, of course, that they recognize it.

TRACHALIO
Source of villany, do you suppose that all other people are just like yourself, you author of perjury?

GRIPUS
All this I easily put up with, so long as he ((pointing to DAEMONES)) is of my way of thinking [104] .

TRACHALIO
But now he is against you; from this ((pointing to the wallet)) will he obtain true testimony.

DAEMONES
Gripus, do you pay attention. ((To TRACHALIO.)) You explain in a few words what it is you want?

TRACHALIO
For my part, I have stated it; but if you haven't understood me, I'll state it over again. Both of these women ((pointing to them)) , as I said a short time since, ought to be free;
((pointing to PALAESTRA)) she was stolen at Athens when a little girl.

GRIPUS
Tell me what that has got to do with the wallet, whether they are slaves or whether free women?

TRACHALIO
You wish it all to be told over again, you rascal, so that the day may fail us.

DAEMONES
Leave off your abuse, and explain to me what I've been asking.

TRACHALIO
There ought to be a casket of wicker-work [105] in that wallet,
in which are tokens by means of which she may be enabled to recognize her parents, by whom, when little, she was lost at Athens, as I said before.

GRIPUS
May Jupiter and the Gods confound you. What do you say, you sorcerer of a fellow? What, are these women dumb, that they are not able to speak for themselves?

TRACHALIO
They are silent for this reason, because a silent woman is always better than a talking one.

GRIPUS
Then, I' faith, by your way of speaking, you are neither a man nor a woman to my notion.

TRACHALIO
How so?

GRIPUS
Why, because neither talking nor silent are you ever good for anything. Prithee ((to DAEMONES)) , shall I ever be allowed to-day to speak?

DAEMONES
If you utter a single word more this day, I'll break your head for you.

TRACHALIO
As I had commenced to say it, old gentleman, I beg you
to order him to give up that casket to these young women; if for it he asks any reward for himself, it shall be paid;

whatever else is there besides, let him keep for himself.

GRIPUS
Now at last you say that, because you are aware it is my right; just now you were asking to go halves.

TRACHALIO
Aye, and even still I ask it.

GRIPUS
I've seen a kite making a swoop, even when he got nothing at all however.

DAEMONES
((to GRIPUS.))
Can't I shut your mouth without a drubbing?

GRIPUS
((pointing to TRACHALIO.))
If that fellow is silent, I'll be silent; if he talks, allow me to talk in my own behalf.

DAEMONES
Please now give me this wallet, Gripus.

GRIPUS
I'll trust it to you; but for you to return it me, if there are none of those things in it.

DAEMONES
It shall be returned.

GRIPUS
Take it. ((Gives him the wallet.))

DAEMONES
Now then listen, Palaestra and Ampelisca, to this which I say:
is this the wallet, in which this Procurer said that your casket was?

PALAESTRA
It is the same.

GRIPUS
((aside.))
Troth, to my sorrow, I'm undone; how on the instant, before she well saw it, she said that it was it.

PALAESTRA
I'll make this matter plain to you, instead of difficult. There ought to be a casket of wicker-work there in that wallet; whatever is in there I'll state by name; don't you
show me anything. If I say wrong, I shall then have said this to no purpose; then you shall keep these things, whatever is in there for yourselves. But if the truth, then I entreat you that what is my own may be restored to me.

DAEMONES
I agree; you ask for bare justice only, in my way of thinking, at least.

GRIPUS
But, I' faith, in mine, for extreme injustice; what if she is a witch or a sorceress,
and shall mention exactly everything that's in it. Is a sorceress to have it?

DAEMONES
She shan't get it, unless she tells the truth; in vain will she [106] be conjuring. Unloose the wallet, then ((giving it to GRIPUS)) , that as soon as possible I may know what is the truth.

GRIPUS
((first unfastens the straps of the wallet, and then hands it to his MASTER.))
Take it [107] , it's unfastened. ((DAEMONES takes out the casket.)) Alas, I'm undone; I see the casket.

DAEMONES
((holding it up, and addressing PALAESTRA.))
Is this it?

PALAESTRA
That is it. O my parents, here do I keep you locked up;
here have I enclosed both my wealth and my hopes of recognizing you.

GRIPUS
((aside.))
Then, by my faith, the Gods must be enraged with you, whoever you are, who fasten up your parents in so narrow a compass.

DAEMONES
Gripus, come hither, your cause is being tried. ((To PALAESTRA.)) Do you, young woman, away at a distance there say what's in it, and of what appearance; mention them all.
By my troth, if you make ever so slight a mistake, even if afterwards you wish, madam, to correct yourself, you'll be making a great mistake.

GRIPUS
You demand what's real justice.

TRACHALIO
By my troth, then, he doesn't demand yourself; for you are the opposite of justice.

DAEMONES
Now then, say on, young woman. Gripus, give attention and hold your tongue.

PALAESTRA
There are some trinkets.

DAEMONES
((looking in the casket.))

See, here they are, I espy them.

GRIPUS
((aside.))
In the first onset I am worsted;
((takes hold of the arm of DAEMONES)) hold, don’t be showing.

DAEMONES
Of what description are they? Answer in their order.

PALAESTRA
In the first place, there’s a little sword of gold, with an inscription.

DAEMONES
Just tell me, what the characters are upon that little sword.

PALAESTRA
The name of my father. Next, on the other side, there’s a little two-edged axe, of gold likewise, with an inscription: there on the axe is the name of my mother.

DAEMONES
Stay;
tell me, what’s the name of your father upon the little sword?

PALAESTRA
Daemones.

DAEMONES
Immortal Gods! where in the world are my hopes?

GRIPUS
Aye, by my troth, and where are mine?

DAEMONES
Do proceed forthwith, I entreat you.

GRIPUS
Cautiously, or else ((aside)) away to utter perdition.

DAEMONES
Say, what’s the name of your mother, here upon the little axe?

PALAESTRA
Daedalis.

DAEMONES
The Gods will that I should be preserved.

GRIPUS
But that I should be ruined.

DAEMONES
This must be my own daughter, Gripus.

GRIPUS
She may be for me, indeed. ((To TRACHALIO.)) May all the Gods confound you who this day saw me with your eyes, and myself as well for a blockhead, who didn't look about a hundred times first to see that no one was watching me, before I drew the net out of the water.

PALAESTRA
Next, there's a little knife of silver, and two little hands linked together, and
then a little sow.

GRIPUS
((aside.))
Nay, then, go and be hanged, you with your little sow and with your little pigs.

PALAESTRA
There's also a golden drop [108] , which my father presented to me upon my birthday.

DAEMONES
Undoubtedly there is; but I cannot restrain myself any longer from embracing you. My daughter, blessings on you; I am that father who begot you; I am Daemones, and see, your mother Daedalis is in the house here ((pointing to his cottage)) .

AMPELISCA
((embracing him.))
Blessings on you, my unlooked-for father.

DAEMONES
Blessings on you; how joyously do I embrace you.

TRACHALIO
'Tis a pleasure to me, inasmuch as this falls to your lot from your feelings of affection.

DAEMONES
Come then, Trachalio, if you can, bring that wallet into the house.

TRACHALIO
((taking the wallet.))
See the villany of Gripus; inasmuch, Gripus, as this matter has turned out unfortunately for you, I congratulate you.

DAEMONES
Come, then, let's go, my daughter, to your mother,
who will be better able to enquire of you into this matter from proofs; who had you more in her hands, and is more

thoroughly acquainted with your tokens.

TRACHALIO
Let’s all go hence in-doors, since we are giving our common aid.

PALAESTRA
Follow me, Ampelisca.

AMPELISCA
That the Gods favour you, it is a pleasure to me. ((They all go into the cottage of DAEMONES, exceptGRIPUS.))

GRIPUS
((to himself.))
Am I not a blockhead of a fellow, to have this day fished up that wallet?
Or, when I had fished it up, not to have hidden it somewhere in a secret spot? By my troth, I guessed that it would be a troublesome booty for me, because it fell to me in such troublous weather. I’ faith, I guess that there’s plenty of gold and silver there. What is there better for me than to be off hence in-doors and secretly hang myself—
at least for a little time, until this vexation passes away from me? ((Goes into the cottage.))

((Enter DAEMONES, from his cottage.))

DAEMONES
((to himself.))
O ye immortal Gods, what person is there more fortunate than I, who unexpectedly have discovered my daughter? Isn’t it the fact, that if the Gods will a blessing to befall any person, that longed-for pleasure by some means or other, falls to the lot [109] of the virtuous?
I this day, a thing that I never hoped for nor yet believed, have unexpectedly discovered my daughter, and I shall bestow her upon a respectable young man of noble family, an Athenian, and my kinsman. For that reason I wish him to be fetched hither to me as soon as possible,
and I’ve requested my servant to come out here, that he may go to the Forum. Still, I’m surprised at it that he isn’t yet come out. I think I’ll go to the door. ((Opens the door, and looks in.)) What do I behold? Embracing her, my wife is clasping my daughter around her neck. Her caressing is really almost too foolish and sickening.

DAEMONES
((Goes to the door again, and calls out.))
’Twere better, wife, for an end to be made at last of your kissing; and make all ready that I may perform a sacrifice, when I come in-doors, in honor of the household Gods, inasmuch as they have increased our family. At home I have lambs and swine for sacred use. But why, ladies, are you detaining that Trachalio? Oh, I see he’s coming out of doors, very seasonably. ((Enter TRACHALIO, from the cottage.))

TRACHALIO
((speaking to those within.))
Wheresoever he shall be, I’ll seek Plesidippus out at once, and bring him together with me to you.

DAEMONES
Tell him how this matter has fallen out about my daughter. Request him to leave other occupations and to come here.

TRACHALIO
Very well [110]

DAEMONES
Tell him that I'll give him my daughter for a wife.

TRACHALIO
Very well.

DAEMONES
And that I knew his father, and that he is a relation of my own.

TRACHALIO
Very well.

DAEMONES
But do make haste.

TRACHALIO
Very well.

DAEMONES
Take care and let a dinner be prepared here at once.

TRACHALIO
Very well.

DAEMONES
What, all very well?

TRACHALIO
Very well. But do you know what it is I want of you? That you'll remember what you promised, that this day I'm to be free.

DAEMONES
Very well [111] .

TRACHALIO
Take care and entreat Plesidippus to give me my freedom.

DAEMONES
Very well.

TRACHALIO
And let your daughter request it; she'll easily prevail.

DAEMONES
Very well.

TRACHALIO
And that Ampelisca may marry me, when I’m a free man.

DAEMONES
Very well.

TRACHALIO
And that I may experience a pleasing return to myself in kindness for my actions.

DAEMONES
Very well.

TRACHALIO
What, all very well?

DAEMONES
Very well. Again I return you thanks. But do you make haste to proceed to the city forthwith, and betake yourself hither again.

TRACHALIO
Very well. I’ll be here directly. In the meanwhile, do you make the other preparations that are necessary. ((Exit TRACHALIO.))

DAEMONES
Very well—
may Hercules ill befriend him with his very-welling [112] ; he has so stuffed my ears with it. Whatever it was I said, very well was the answer.

((Enter GRIPUS, from the cottage.))

GRIPUS
How soon may I have a word with you, Daemones?

DAEMONES
What’s your business, Gripus?

GRIPUS
Touching that wallet, if you are wise, be wise; keep what goods the Gods provide you.

DAEMONES
Does it seem right to you, that, what belongs to another I should assert to be my own?

GRIPUS
What, not a thing that I found in the sea?

DAEMONES
So much the better does it happen for him who lost it; none the more is it necessary that it should be your wallet.

GRIPUS
For this reason are you poor because you are too scrupulously righteous.

DAEMONES
O Gripus, Gripus, in the life of man very many traps there are, in what they are deceived by guile. And, by my troth, full often is a bait placed in them, which bait if any greedy person greedily snaps at, through his own greediness he is caught in the trap.
He who prudently, skilfully, and warily, takes precaution, full long he may enjoy that which is honestly acquired. This booty seems to me [113] to be about to be made a booty of by me, that it may go hence with a greater blessing than it first came. What, ought I to conceal what I know was brought to me as belonging to another? By no means will my friend Daemones do that. 'Tis ever most becoming for prudent men to be on their guard against this, that they be not themselves confederates with their servants in evil-doing. Except only when I'm gaming, I don't care for any gain.

GRIPUS
At times, I've seen the Comedians, when acting, in this fashion
repeat sayings in a wise manner, and be applauded for them, when they pointed out this prudent conduct to the public. But when each person went thence his own way home, there wasn't one after the fashion which they had recommended.

DAEMONES
Go in-doors, don't be troublesome, moderate your tongue. I'm going to give you nothing, don't you deceive yourself.

GRIPUS
((apart.))
Then I pray the Gods that whatever's in that wallet, whether it's gold, or whether silver, it may all become ashes. ((Goes into the cottage.))

DAEMONES
This is the reason why we have bad servants. For this master, if he had combined with any servant,
would have made both himself and the other guilty of a theft. While he was thinking that he himself had made a capture, in the meantime he himself would have been made a capture: capture would have led to capture. Now will I go in-doors from here and sacrifice; after that, I'll at once order the dinner to be cooked for us. ((Goes into the cottage.))

((Enter PLESIDIPPUS and TRACHALIO, at the further end of the stage.))

PLESIDIPPUS
Tell me all these things over again my life, my Trachalio, my freed-man, my patron, aye rather, my father; has Palaestra found her father and mother?

TRACHALIO
She has found them.

PLESIDIPPUS
And is she my countrywoman?

TRACHALIO
So I think.

PLESIDIPPUS
And is she to marry me?

TRACHALIO
So I suspect.

PLESIDIPPUS
Prithee, do you reckon that he will betroth her to me?

TRACHALIO
So I reckon [114] .

PLESIDIPPUS
Well, shall I congratulate her father too upon his finding her?

TRACHALIO
So I reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
Well, her mother too?

TRACHALIO
So I reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
What then do you reckon?

TRACHALIO
What you ask me, I reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
Tell me then how much do you reckon it at?

TRACHALIO
What I, I reckon—

PLESIDIPPUS
Then really, do carry over [115] . Don’t be always making a reckoning.

TRACHALIO
So I reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
What if I run? ((Pretends to run.))

TRACHALIO
So I reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
Or rather gently, this way? ((He walks slowly.))

TRACHALIO
So I reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
Ought I to salute her as well when I arrive?

TRACHALIO
So I reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
Her father too?

TRACHALIO
So I reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
After that, her mother?

TRACHALIO
So I reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
And what after that? When I arrive, should I also embrace her father?

TRACHALIO
So I don’t reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
Well, her mother?

TRACHALIO
So I don’t reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
Well, her own self?

TRACHALIO
So I don’t reckon.

PLESIDIPPUS
Confusion, he has closed his reckoning [116] ; now when I wish him, he doesn’t reckon.

TRACHALIO
You are not in your senses; follow me.

PLESIDIPPUS
Conduct me, my patron, where you please. ((They go into the cottage of DAEMONES.))

((Enter LABRAX, at a distance.))

LABRAX
((to himself.))
What other mortal being is there living this day more wretched than myself, whom before the commissioned judges [117] Plesidippus has just now cast? Palaestra has just been taken from me by award. I'm ruined outright. But I do believe that Procurers were procreated for mere sport;
so much do all persons make sport if any misfortune befalls a Procurer. Now I'll go look here, in the Temple of Venus, for that other female, that her at least I may take away, the only portion of my property that remains. ((He retires a little distance.))

((Enter GRIPUS, from the cottage of DAEMONES, with a spit in his hand.))

GRIPUS
((calling to the PEOPLE within.))
By the powers, you shall never this day at nightfall behold Gripus alive, unless the wallet is restored to me.

LABRAX
((behind.))
I'm ready to die; when I hear mentior made anywhere of a wallet, I'm thumped, as it were with a stake, upon the breast.

GRIPUS
((at the door, continuing.))
That scoundrel is free; I, the person that held the net in the sea, and drew up the wallet, to him you refuse to give anything.

LABRAX
((behind.))
O ye immortal Gods! by his talk this person has made me prick up my ears.

GRIPUS
((continuing.))
By my troth, in letters a cubit long, I'll immediately post it up in every quarter,
If any person has lost a wallet with plenty of gold and silver, let him come to Gripus. You shan't keep it as you are wishing.

LABRAX
((behind.))
I' faith, this person knows, as I think, who has got the wallet. This person must be accosted by me; ye Gods, aid me, I do entreat you. ((Some one calls GRIPUS, from within.))

GRIPUS
Why are you calling me back in-doors? ((He rubs away at the spit.)) I want to clean this here before the door. But surely this, I’ faith, has been made of rust, and not of iron; so that the more I rub it, it becomes quite red and more slender. Why surely this spit has been drugged [118] ; it does waste away so in my hands.

LABRAX
((accosting him.))
Save you, young man.

GRIPUS
May the Gods prosper you with your shorn pate [119] .

LABRAX
What’s going on?

GRIPUS
A spit being cleaned.

LABRAX
How do you do?

GRIPUS
What are you? Prithee, are you a medicant [120] ?

LABRAX
No, I’ faith, I am more than a medicant by one letter.

GRIPUS
Then you are a mendicant.

LABRAX
You’ve hit it to a nicety [121] .

GRIPUS
Your appearance seems suitable to it. But what’s the matter with you?

LABRAX
Troth, this last night I was shipwrecked at sea the vessel was cast away, and to my misfortune I lost there everything that I had.

GRIPUS
What did you lose?

LABRAX
A wallet with plenty of gold and silver.

GRIPUS

Do you at all remember what there was in the wallet which was lost?

LABRAX
What matters for us now to be talking of it, if, in spite of it, it’s lost?

GRIPUS
What if I know who has found it? I wish to learn from you the tokens.

LABRAX
Eight hundred golden pieces were there in a purse, besides a hundred Philippean minae in a wash-leather bag apart.

GRIPUS
((aside.))
Troth, it is a noble prize; I shall be getting a handsome reward. The Gods show respect to mortals; therefore I shall come off bounteously rewarded. No doubt, it is this man’s wallet. ((To LABRAX.)) Do you proceed to relate the rest.

LABRAX
A large talent of silver of full weight was in a purse, besides a bowl, a goblet, a beaker, a boat, and a cup.

GRIPUS
Astonishing! you really did have some splendid riches.

LABRAX
A shocking expression is that, and a most abominable one. You did have, and now have not.

GRIPUS
What would you be ready to give to one who should find these out for you, and give you information? Say, speedily and at once.

LABRAX
Three hundred didrachms.

GRIPUS
Rubbish.

LABRAX
Four hundred.

GRIPUS
Old thrums.

LABRAX
Five hundred.

GRIPUS
A rotten nut.

LABRAX
Six hundred.

GRIPUS
You are prating about mere tiny weevils.

LABRAX
I'll give seven hundred.

GRIPUS
Your mouth is hot, you are cooling it [122] just now.

LABRAX
I'll give a thousand didrachms.

GRIPUS
You are dreaming.

LABRAX
I add no more;
be off with you.

GRIPUS
Hear me then; if, I' faith, I should be off from here, I shan't be here.

LABRAX
[123] Would you like a hundred as well as the thousand?

GRIPUS
You are asleep.

LABRAX
Say how much you ask.

GRIPUS
That you mayn't be adding anything against your inclination,
a great talent; it's not possible for three obols to be bated thence; then do you say either yes or no at once.

LABRAX
((aside.))
What's to be done here? It's a matter of necessity, I see: ((to GRIPUS)) the talent shall be paid.

GRIPUS
((going towards the altar.))
Just step this way; I wish Venus here to put the question to you.

LABRAX

Whatever you please, that command me.

GRIPUS
Touch this altar of Venus.

LABRAX
((touching it.))
I am touching it.

GRIPUS
By Venus here must you swear to me.

LABRAX
What must I swear?

GRIPUS
What I shall bid you.

LABRAX
Dictate in words just as you like. ((Aside.)) What I’ve got at home, I shall never beg [124] of any one else.

GRIPUS
Take hold of this altar.

LABRAX
((taking hold of it.))
I am taking hold of it.

GRIPUS
Swear that you will pay me the money on that same day on which you shall gain possession of the wallet.

LABRAX
Be it so.

GRIPUS
((speaking, while LABRAX repeats after him.))
Venus of Cyrene, I invoke thee as my witness, if I shall find that wallet which I lost in the ship,
safe with the gold and silver, and it shall come into my possession—Then to this Gripus do I promise; say so and place your hand upon me.

LABRAX
Then to this Gripus do I promise, Venus, do thou hear me—

GRIPUS
((followed by LABRAX.))
That I will forthwith give him a great talent of silver."

GRIPUS

If you defraud me, say, may Venus utterly destroy your body, and your existence in your calling. ((Aside.)) As it is, do you have this for yourself, when you've once taken the oath.

LABRAX
If, Venus, I shall do anything amiss against this oath, I supplicate thee that all Procurers may henceforth be wretched.

GRIPUS
((aside.))
As it is, it shall be so, even if you do keep your oath. Do you wait here; ((going towards the cottage)) —I'll at once make the old gentleman come out; do you forthwith demand of him that wallet. ((Goes in.))

LABRAX
((to himself.))
If ever so much he shall restore to me this wallet, I'm not this day indebted to him three obols even.
It's according to my own intention what my tongue swears. ((The door opens.)) But I'll hold my peace; see, here he's coming out, and bringing the old man.

((Enter GRIPUS, followed by DAEMONES, with the wallet.))

GRIPUS
Follow this way.
Where is this Procurer?
Hark you ((to LABRAX)) , see now; this person ((pointing at DAEMONES)) has got your wallet.

DAEMONES
I have got it, and I confess that it is in my possession; and if it's yours, you may have it. Everything, just as each particular was in it, shall in like manner be given safe to you.
((Holding it out.)) Take it, if it's yours.

LABRAX
Immortal Gods, it is mine. ((Takes it.)) Welcome, dear wallet.

DAEMONES
Is it yours?

LABRAX
Do you ask the question? If indeed, I' faith, it were in Jove's possession, still it is my own.

DAEMONES
Everything in it is safe; there has only been one casket taken out of it, with some trinkets, by means of which this day I have found my daughter.

LABRAX
What person?

DAEMONES
Palaestra, who was your property, she has been discovered to be my own daughter.

LABRAX
By my troth, it has happily turned out so; since this matter has happened so fortunately for you according to your wishes, I'm rejoiced.

DAEMONES
In that I don't readily believe you.

LABRAX
Aye, by my faith, that you may be sure that I'm rejoiced, you shan't give me three obols for her; I excuse you.

DAEMONES
I' faith, you are acting kindly.

LABRAX
No, troth; it's really yourself, indeed, that's doing so. ((Going off with the wallet.))

GRIPUS
Hark you, you've got the wallet now.

LABRAX
I have got it.

GRIPUS
Make haste.

LABRAX
Make haste about what?

GRIPUS
To pay me the money.

LABRAX
By my troth, I'll neither give you anything nor do I owe you anything.

GRIPUS
What mode of proceeding is this? Don't you owe it me?

LABRAX
Troth, not I indeed.

GRIPUS
Didn't you promise it me upon your oath?

LABRAX
I did take an oath, and now I'll take an oath, if it is in any way my own pleasure; oaths were invented for preserving property, not for losing it.

GRIPUS
Give me, will you, a great talent of silver, you most perjured fellow.

DAEMONES
Gripus, what talent is it you are asking him for?

GRIPUS
He promised it me on oath.

LABRAX
I chose to swear; ((turning to DAEMONES)) are you the priest [125] as to my perjury?

DAEMONES
((to GRIPUS.))
For what reason did he promise you the money?

GRIPUS
If I restored this wallet into his hands, he swore that he would give
me a great talent of silver.

LABRAX
Find me a person with whom I may go to the judge, to decide whether you did not make the bargain with wicked fraudulence, and whether I am yet five-and-twenty years old [126] .

GRIPUS
((pointing to DAEMONES.))
Go to the judge with him.

LABRAX
No; I must have some other person.

DAEMONES
((to LABRAX.))
Then I shan’t allow you to take it away from him, unless I shall have found him guilty. Did you promise him the money?

LABRAX
I confess it.

DAEMONES
What you promised my slave
must needs be my own. Don’t you be supposing, Procurer, that you are to be using your pimping honesty here. That can’t be.

GRIPUS
((to LABRAX.))
Did you fancy now that you had got hold of a person whom you might cheat? It must be paid down here ((holding his hand)) , good silver coin; I shall, at once, pay it to him ((pointing to DAEMONES)) , so that he may give me

my liberty.

DAEMONES
Inasmuch, therefore, as I have acted courteously towards you, and by my means these things ((pointing to the wallet)) have been saved for you—

GRIPUS
I’ faith, by my means, rather; don’t say by yours.

DAEMONES
((to GRIPUS.))
If you are prudent you’ll hold your tongue. ((To LABRAX.)) Then it befits you in a like courteous manner kindly to return the obligation to myself, who so well merit the same.

LABRAX
You are pleading, of course, for my right?

DAEMONES
((ironically.))
It would be a wonder if I didn’t, at a loss to myself, ask you to forego your right.

GRIPUS
((aside.))
I’m all right; the Procurer’s giving way; my freedom is at hand.

DAEMONES
((pointing to GRIPUS.))
He found this wallet; he is my slave. I therefore have preserved this for you, together with a large sum of money.

LABRAX
I return you thanks, and with regard to the talent that I promised on oath to him, there’s no reason that you shouldn’t receive it.

GRIPUS
Hark you, give it me then, if you are wise.

DAEMONES
((to GRIPUS.))
Will you hold your tongue, or not?

GRIPUS
You pretend to be acting on my side: I tell you
by my troth, you shan’t do me out of that, if I did lose the other booty [127] .

DAEMONES
You shall have a beating if you add a single word.

GRIPUS

Troth now, do you kill me even; I'll never be silent on any terms, unless my mouth is shut with the talent.

LABRAX
For yourself, in fact, is he using his exertions; do hold your tongue.

DAEMONES
Step this way, Procurer.

LABRAX
Very well. ((They walk on one side.))

GRIPUS
Proceed openly; I don't want any whisperings or mumblings to be going on.

DAEMONES
Tell me, at what price did you buy that other young woman, Ampelisca?

LABRAX
I paid down a thousand didrachms.

DAEMONES
Should you like me to make you a handsome offer?

LABRAX
I should like it much.

DAEMONES
I'll divide the talent.

LABRAX
You act fairly.

DAEMONES
For that other woman Ampelisca, that she may be free, take you one half, and give the other half to him.

LABRAX
By all means.

DAEMONES
For that half I'll give his freedom to Gripus, by means of whom you found your wallet, and I my daughter.

LABRAX
You act fairly; I return you many thanks. ((They return to GRIPUS.))

GRIPUS
How soon then is the money to be returned to me?

DAEMONES

The money’s paid, Gripus; I’ve got it.

GRIPUS
You, faith; but I had rather it were myself.

DAEMONES
I’ faith, there’s nothing for you here, so don’t you be expecting it. I wish you to release him from his oath.

GRIPUS
((aside.))
Troth, I’m undone; if I don’t hang myself [128] , I’m utterly done for. ((Aloud.)) I’ faith, after this day you certainly shall never be cheating me again.

DAEMONES
Dine here to-day, Procurer.

LABRAX
Be it so; the proposal is to my taste.

DAEMONES
Do you both follow me in-doors. ((He comes forward and addresses the AUDIENCE.)) Spectators, I would invite you to dinner as well, were it not that I’m going to give nothing, and that there is no good cheer at all at home; and if, too, I didn’t believe that you are invited to dinner elsewhere. But if you shall be willing to give hearty applause to this Play, do you all come to make merry at my house some sixteen years hence. Do you ((to LABRAX and GRIPUS)) both dine here with me to-day.

GRIPUS
Be it so.

An ACTOR
((To the AUDIENCE))
Now give us your applause. [129]

NOTES

[1] [Supposed to have been written by Priscian the Grammarian.]

[2] Arcturus : This is a star near the tail of the Great Bear, whose rising and setting was supposed to be productive of great tempests. The name is derived from its situation, from the Greek words arktos and oura, the Bear’s tail. It rises in the beginning of October. Pliny mentions it as rising on the 12th, and Columella on the 5th of that month. We may here remark, that the Play is called the Fisherman’s Rope in consequence of the important part which, towards the close, the rope acts in bringing the wallet to shore in the net. The scenery of this Play must have been much more picturesque than that of those of Plautus in general. At the end of the stage is a prospect of the sea, interspersed with rocks in the distance, while others project upon the front of the stage. The City of Cyrene is also seen in the distance; while nearer to the Audience is the Temple of Venus, with an altar in front of it; and adjoining the Temple is the cottage of Daemones. Some other cottages are also seen at a distance. If the comparison may be made, it bears some slight resemblance to the Tempest of Shakspeare.

[3] As you see : The actor is supposed here to point to a star placed on his forehead, or on the head-dress which he wears.

[4] Written down on other tablets : This is not unlike the words of the Psalmist, Psalm lvi., 8: Thou tellest my wanderings; put thou my tears into thy bottle. Are they not in thy book?

[5] Diphilus : He was a Greek Comic Poet, from whom Plautus is supposed to have borrowed the plot of several of his Plays.

[6] Cyrene : This was a famous city of Libya , said to have been founded by Aristaeus, the son of the Nymph Cyrene. It was situate in a fertile plain, about eleven miles from the Mediterranean, and was the capital of a district called Pentapolis , from the five cities which it contained.

[7] This Procurer : Leno. The calling of the lenones was to traffic in young female slaves, to whom they gave an accomplished education, and then sold them or let them out for the purposes of prostitution. The lenones were deservedly reckoned infamous.

[8] Agrigentum : This was a town of Sicily , on Mount Acragas, about two miles from the sea. Its inhabitants were famed for their luxurious mode of living.

[9] To a breakfast : — This probably refers to the meal which took place after the sacrifice, for which certain portions of the victim, particularly the entrails, were reserved. See the Miles Gloriosus, l. 712.

[10] May your foes : The Carthaginians are alluded to; this Play having been written during the second Punic war.

[11] In Euridpides : He alludes to a Tragedy of Euripides so named, where a dreadful storm was so accurately represented that at length the Play became a proverbial expression for tempestuous weather. Madame Dacier observes, that it was not strange for Sceparnio to mention this, as he might often have seen it represented at Athens upon the stage. This notion is somewhat far-fetched, as it is not likely that Plautns troubled himself about such a fine point, or that the Audience was gifted with any such nicety of perception as to note his accuracy, even if he had. It has been suggested, and not at all improbably, that Plautus borrowed the Scene of the thunder and lightning in his Amphitryon from this Play of Euripides.

[12] Plenty of clay : He probably means clay for the purpose of drying and making tiles with it.

[13] Some reeds : From this we learn that the cottage of Daemones was covered with a kind of thatch. This and l. 18 of the Miles Gloriosus are probably the earliest instances in which thatched roofs are mentioned.

[14] A pot for cooking : Aula extaris. Literally, a pot for holding the entrails of the animals sacrificed.

[15] Been invited here : It was the custom of Parasites to prowl about the Temples, for the purpose of joining in the feasts which sometimes took place at the conclusion of the sacrifice.

[16] To a parting breakfast : Prandium propter viam. Thornton has the following Note here: This is a sorry joke, even for Sceparnio, on so serious and melancholy an occasion, and cannot be well expressed in our tongue. When the ancients were about to undertake any voyage, they used to make a sacrifice to Hercules before they set off, which was for that reason called propter viam; and the custom was to burn all they didn’t eat. Wherefore Sceparnio

says laverunt, which signifies they have consumed their all as well as they have bathed. alluding to the ship being lost.

[17] Palaemon : This was one of the names of Melicerta. or Portunus, the son of Athamas and Ino. Athamas being about to slay him and Ino, they leaped into the sea, where they became sea Divinities.

[18] I follow : The Scene of the wreck, previously described by Sceparnio, was probably not visible to the Audience, but was depicted by him while directing his view towards the side of the stage.

[19] If she at least : Exactly the same sentiment occurs to Defoe's hero, Robinson Crusoe, when he visits the Spanish ship wrecked off his island: I cannot explain by any possible energy of words what a strange longing or hankering of desires I felt in my soul upon this sight, breaking out sometimes thus, O that there had been but one or two, nay, or but one soul saved out of this ship, to have escaped to me, that I might have had one companion, one fellow-creature to have spoken to me and to have conversed with!

[20] Neither, indeed, do I see : She is unable to see the Temple of Venus and the house of Daemones, by reason of the high crags among which she is wandering, some of which are represented in the front of the stage.

[21] Part of line 237c in the Latin.

[22] Tell me where : It must be remembered that they are still separated by the crags upon the stage, though they are both visible to the Audience.

[23] The wooden steed : Homer calls ships horses of the sea.

[24] Limpets : Balanos. It is not known what shellfish the balani really were.

[25] Spotted crabs : It is not known what kind of fish the plagusia was.

[26] Soaked in salt water : — Salsi lautique pure. Thornton says, Madame Dacier supposes that a joke is intended here, from the equivocal meaning of the words, which might mean that they had been entertained with high-seasoned cates, or that they had been washed and cleansed with salt water. salsi, says she, because sea-water is salt; pure, because sea-water washed away all impurities.

[27] Shellfish-gatherers and hook-fishers : Conchitae — hamistae. These words are supposed to have been coined by Plautus for the occasion.

[28] How perish apace : Thornton has this Note here: There is an humour in the original which could not be preserved in our language. Instead of asking the fishermen Ut valetis? which was the common phrase of salutation, Trachalio addresses them in the opposite term, Ut peritis? —probably un allusion to their perilous calling.

[29] Not far advanced : She seems to mean that, in the prime of life her misfortunes are greater than might have been anticipated by one so young

[30] Right pleasant throw : There is a joke here, which depends on the double meaning of jacere bolum and perdere. The former signifies, to cast a net and to cast a throw of dice. Perdere signifies, to cause to perish, and to break or ruin, in the gamester's sense.

[31] Cup of necessity : Anancaeum, the cup of necessity, which derived its name from the Greek word a nagke, necessity, was so called from the custom, in feasts, of handing round a large goblet, which all were obliged to empty, without losing a drop. Trachalio alludes to the large draught of salt water which he supposes Labrax has had to swallow at the bidding of Neptune.

[32] Very dainty Aedile : It was the duty of the Aediles at Rome to visit the markets and inspect the wares, like the Agoranomus, or market-officer, of the Greeks. See the Miles Gloriosus, l. 727, and the Note.

[33] Let my hair grow : It is supposed to have been the custom of soothsayers and diviners to let their hair grow to a greater length than usual

[34] For just now I’ve no means : This line has greatly puzzled the Commentators. Sceparnio, however, seems to mean that at present he is busy, and cannot attend to her, but that in the evening he will be at her service. It has been suggested that a double entendre is meant; and such may possibly be the case, though the pungency of the passage is lost by reason of the hiatus in the next line. The meaning may, however, be harmless, and he may intend to say that at present he is busy thatching the house, but that at nightfall he will have finished, when she may count upon being hospitably entertained.

[35] Of the vulture’s tint : There is a poor joke here upon the words subaquilum and subvulturium. Sceparnio means to describe the complexion of Ampelisca as somewhat resembling the colour of an eagle. By mistake, he happens to mention a vulture, and immediately corrects himself, as, from its sordid habits, he may be deemed to be paying her an ill compliment.

[36] No common commodity for the whole township : Pollucta pago. The portion of the sacrifice to Hercules which was given to the common people was said to be pollucta, whence the present adaptation of the epithet. Echard seems to have contemplated translating this, I’m no pie for every one’s cutting up!

[37] With all deference : Praefiscine. This word was generally used as being supposed to avert the evil eye, when persons spake in high terms of themselves. There is some drollery in Sceparnio using it, when speaking in disparagement of himself.

[38] Of being in love : Not for the pleasure of loving, but for the comparative ease of drawing the water, which was probably one of his employments.

[39] Playing bo-peep : Both Horace and Virgil mention the game of hiding, or bo-peep, as a favorite one with the girls of their day

[40] Who were never wiling : He probably alludes to some current proverb of the day, which may, with considerable truth, have said that liberty forsakes a man when he goes or board ship.

[41] Even more wealth : He means that he has not only lost his existing property by the shipwreck, but his hopes of profit as well on his arrival at Sicily , by means of his traffic with Palaestra and Ampelisca.

[42] Thyestes and Tereus : Atreus killed the children of his brother Thyestes, and served them up to their father. Progne slew her son Itys, and set him before his father Tereus, who had ravished and mutilated her sister Philomela.

[43] Have made you salt : Ex insulso salsum. The humour in this passage depends on the double meaning of the

word salsus, which signifies saited, and, figuratively, sharp, clever. witty.

[44] For a skirmishing fight : Thornton has this Note on this passage: Velitatio signifies a skirmish, which was. usually made by the velites, that is, the light-harnessed soldiers; and these men always made use of darts, whose points would glitter at a distance, sometimes one way, and sometimes another. Now Charmides, trembling with cold, compares himself to these velites, or skirmishers, who never keep their places; and his words, which came out broken and by piecemeal, to the unequal glimmerings or flashes of their darts.

[45] Hot-liquor shop : See the Trinummus, l. 1013, and the Note.

[46] For a hobgoblin : Manducus was a huge figure exhibited on the stage and at public shows, with huge teeth craunching, and a wide mouth—probably not unlike some of the idols of the South Sea Islanders.

[47] Payment to everybody : He means, that his readiness to commit perjury will save him the trouble of finding money to pay with as he can always swear that he has paid already.

[48] Washed bare : The poor joke here turns on the double meaning of the word eluo, which, in the passive, means to be shipwrecked, and in the active, either to bathe or to be ruined in one's fortunes. It is not very dissimilar to an expression common with us, and might be rendered, I wasn't cleaned out enough at sea fast night, but you want to clean me out still more. Sceparnio takes the word in the sense of to bathe, and says, Bathe or anoint yourself; I don't care a fig. Anointing followed immediately after bathing,

[49] One fig : Ciccum. Ciccum was the thin skin in the pomegranate that divided the kernels.

[50] For money : His meaning is, he is so inhuman, that surely he is a slave-dealer, and nothing less.

[51] Has no bowels : Non est misericors. Literally, he is not merciful.

[52] Were Greek wines : He uses this comparison because it was the custom of the ancients to mix sea-water with all the Greek wines, except the Chian, which Horace styles maris expers, unmixed with the sea.

[53] In wondrous ways : It is somewhat singular that the same three lines as this and the two following occur in the Mercator, at the beginning of Act II.

[54] Of Philomela : The Poets generally represent Progne as changed into a swallow, and Philomela into a nightingale. Ovid, however, on one occasion, mentions Philomela as being changed into a swallow. They were the daughters of Pandion, king of Athens , the native place of Daemones.

[55] Laserwort and silphium : Sirpe and laserpitium seem to be different names for the same plant, laserwort, from which assafœtida is distilled. It grew abundantly in Cyrene, which region Catullus calls Laserpitiferae Cyrenae. The juice of this plant seems to have been used in making certain perfumes, for which reason it was exported to Capua .

[56] At Capua —Ver. 631. Capua was the chief city of Campania , in Italy , and was famed for its luxury. It was celebrated for its choice perfumes; and in it there was one great street called Seplasia, which consisted entirely of shops, in which unguents and perfumes were sold.

[57] Juice of silphium : Magudaris is the root or juice of the plant called laserpicium.

[58] Part of line 658b in the Latin.

[59] Cooks do cuttle-fish : This, probably, was a practice of ancient cookery, which, happily, has not come down to our times.

[60] The inner side : Signo intumo may either mean the statue in the most distant and sacred recess, or the inner side of the statue, to which spot they had retired for safety.

[61] Trust me : At the same time he is afraid to go in. Palaestra sees this, and taunts him with being brave—in words only.

[62] In reality : Re, in reality, in contradistinction to words.

[63] End of sentence is part of line 686 in the Latin.

[64] Your bulwarks : Moenia. Madame Dacier supposes that these words refer to the walls of a court in front of the Temple, represented on the stage with an altar in the middle, the walls being breast high, which Trachalio compares to entrenchments.

[65] Not so well attended to : Bene lautum. There is a joke intended in the use of these words, which may signify either quite tidy or properly arranged; or, on the other hand, well washed, neglect of which certainly could not be imputed to them, by reason of their recent shipwreck.

[66] Born from a shell : He alludes to the birth of Venus, who was said to have sprung from the sea in a shell. He also seems to joke upon the destitute state of the young women, and to call them mere shells. An indelicate construction has been, by some, put upon the use of the word conchas, while others think it refers to the use made by women of shells, for holding their paints, perfumes, and cosmetics, and that he means thereby to reproach Venus for having allowed them to lose all their property. This, however, seems to be a rather far-fetched notion.

[67] I wanted that : He means that the women have done as he wished them to do, in flying to the altar for refuge.

[68] A hang-gallows : Furcifero. He sneeringly alludes to Trachalio’s position as a slave, and his liability to have the punishment of the furca inflicted on him.

[69] A hand-ball : These lines are thus rendered in one version: Instantly I will make you a prize-fighting pair of bellows, and while you are drawing breath, will belabour you with my fists. The allusion, however, is clearly to a ball blown up like our footballs, and struck with the clenched fist, the merit of the game being not to let it come to the ground.

[70] Away from here : Foras. Probably in allusion to the court before the Temple

[71] Part of line 727 in the Latin.

[72] Beds of myrtle : Myrteta. This may allude to bundles of myrtle (which was sacred to Venus), bound with rushes and hung about the Temple, or else to beds of myrtle in front of the Temple, with small fences round them, made of rushes.

[73] Thrice-dotted villain : Trifurcifer. Literally, one punished with the furca three times, meaning a thief; or villain three times over. See the Aulularia, l. 281, and the Note (where read punished with the furca).

[74] Genuine Greece : Perhaps in contradistinction to Sicily , which was only colonized by Greeks.

[75] Compliments : Offerumenta, according to Festus, signified an offering to the Gods; and as these were fixed to the walls of the Temples, Trachalio calls the lashes of the scourge or rod, when applied to the back of the delinquent slave, by the same term.

[76] Ship of war : Longa navis. Literally, a long ship. Ships of war were thus called by the Greeks.

[77] Leather flask maker : Ampullarius. A maker of ampullae, or leather bottles. They were of a big-bellied form, with a narrow neck.

[78] An enemy to Venus : In so saying, he alludes to the intrigue of Venus with Mars, which was discovered by the device of Vulcan, her injured husband. For the story, see the Metamorphoses of Ovid, B. 4, l. 73, and the Art of Love, B. 2, l. 562.

[79] Fists for your pitchforks : Mergis pugneis. Echard, in his translation, explains this: As they lift up their pitchforks to heap corn, so will I lift up my fists, and heap a whole harvest of cuffs on your face. Merga means a pitchfork; and, according to Festus, it was so called from its resemblance when dipped into the hay to the action of the mergus, or didapper when dipping into the sea.

[80] To be burning : Festus tells us that humanum was a mortuary sacrifice, or offering to the dead. In his question, therefore, Daemones inplies a wish to know whether Labrax is about to put an end to himself. It was allowable to drive away those who fled to the altar by the agency of fire.

[81] Their inclination—a reception : Invitos—invitassitis. He here plays upon the resemblance of the words invitos, signifying against their will, and invito, being a verb signifying to invite, and admitting of much the same equivocal use as our expression, to give a warm reception to.

[82] Temple of Hercules : Seeing the servants with their cudgels, he is reminded of Hercules, who was thus depicted, and was called by the Poets Claviger.

[83] Not my Palaestra : Echard, borrowing the notion from Madame Dacier, has the following Note on this passage: This Palaestra was a place of public exercise, over the gate of which was a statue of Hercules, with an inscription Palaestra; now Labrax, finding this stout fellow with his club, whom before he had compared to Hercules, answering instead of Palaestra, he wittily alludes to that statue, and says that that Palaestra was none of his. Thornton appears to be right in considering this a far-fetched conceit on the part of the fair Commentatress.

[84] Seized by your throat wrenched : Rapin te obtorto collo. Echard has the following Note: When any person was brought before the Praetor, they always threw his gown or cloak about his neck, and led him that way; and this was called rapi obtorto collo.

[85] Carry her off : There is a play or quibble here upon the words avehere and provehere, to carry away, and to put on board ship, for the purpose of being carried away.

[86] Part of line 881c in the Latin.

[87] Once already : He alludes to the drenching he has had in the sea, by reason of his acquaintance with Labrax, and means to say that one such reception is quite sufficient for his life.

[88] A stock-dove : He puns upon the resemblance between the word columbar, a collar, into which the head was inserted by way of punishment, and columbus, a pigeon. The notion of preserving the pun, by using the word stock-dove, is Echard's. The plural of the word columbar was also used to signify a dove-cot.

[89] Echard remarks that the interval between the last Act and this is filled up with Plesidippus carrying Labrax before the Praetor and his trial, an, likewise with what passes in Daemones' house.

[90] The Praetor : The slave about to be manumitted, or to receive his freedom, was taken before the Praetor, whose lictor laid the vindicta or festuca, the rod of liberty, on the head of the slave, on which he received his freedom.

[91] Land and houses : Is not this wonderfully like Alnaschar's reverie in the Arabian Nights, so aptly quoted in the Spectator?

[92] Stratonicus : He was the treasurer of Philip of Macedon and Alexander the Great, and was famed for his wealth among the Greeks, as Crassus was among the Romans.

[93] Upon vinegar : He alludes to the posca, or vinegar and water, which formed the beverage of the slaves, and which is mentioned by Palaestrio in the Miles Gloriosus, l. 836.

[94] This rope : This is the first mention of the rudens, or netrope, from which the Play derives its name.

[95] Claimed as having a right to freedom : Manu asserere was to assert or claim the liberty of a slave by action at law. Gripus applies the term to the fish of the sea, and means to say that when he catches them, he sells them as his own venales, or slaves.

[96] Article that's made : Vas. An utensil or article that is manufactured.

[97] Maker of wallets : Vitor, or vietor, was a maker of viduli, or wallets, which were made of osier, and then covered with leather of various colours.

[98] Thales : Thales of Miletus was one of the seven wise men of Greece . Gripus ironically calls Trachalio by this name, in reply to the other having called him a fool.

[99] With a polypus fish : The polypus not being eatable, the fishermen would throw it violently on the ground on finding it in the nets.

[100] Propose—dispose : -2. He plays on the resemblance of the words refero , to make a proposal, and aufero , to betake one's self away,

[101] Rather than I : Daemones here alludes to the disposition of his wife, and says that if the damsels do not quit his house, he shall be obliged to do so in self-defence.

[102] Has he got the better : In the use of the word comprimere, an indecent double entendre is intended; and

agreeing with Gripus's remark, that the word in that sense could not be applied to him, Daemones says that Gripus is right there, at all events.

[103] The trinkets : These crepundia, trinkets or toys, seem to have been not unlike the amulets, or charms, in metal, of the present day. As kidnapping was in ancient times much more prevalent than now, these little articles, if carefully preserved by the child, might be the means of leading to the discovery of its parents; at the same time it may be Justly asked how it came to pass that the kidnapper should allow such damning evidence of his villany to remain in existence.

[104] Of my way of thinking : Dum hic hinc à me sentiat. This is clearly the meaning, though one translation renders this line thus: I easily bear all those things until this fellow may feel that he must go away hence from me, and TRACHALIO moves farther off as he delivers the next line.

[105] Casket of wicker-work : Caudeam. Festus tells us that this kind of casket was made of wicker, and received its name from its resemblance to a horse's tail, cauda; others, however, perhaps with more probability, derive it from caudex, a piece of wood.

[106] In vain will she : By this he clearly means to say that conjuring is all nonsense, and that she has no chance of telling what is in it merely by guessing.

[107] Take it : Hoc habe. This, though not adopted by Fleckeisen, seems to be the right reading, and we have followed the conjecture of the learned Rost in adopting it. Gripus undoes the strap, then holds the wallet to his master, saying, Take it, it's unfastened. Daemones takes it, and at once draws out the casket, on seeing which Girpus makes an exclamation of surprise and disappointment.

[108] A golden drop : The bulla was a ball of metal, so called from its resemblance in shape to a drop or bubble of water. These were especially worn by the Roman children, suspended from the neck, and were generally made of thin plates of gold, of about the size of a walnut. The use of them was derived from the people of Etruria, and though originally used solely by the children of the Patricians, they were subsequently worn by all of free birth. The children of the libertini, or freed-men, wore bullae, but made of leather. The bulla was laid aside at the same time as the toga praetexta, and was on that occasion consecrated to the Lares. It must be owned that the little sow, mentioned in the line before, was rather a curious sort of trinket. Thornton thinks that the word sucula admitted of a double entendre, though of what nature is now unknown.

[109] Falls to the lot : He forgets here that Self-praise is no recommendation.

[110] Very well : Licet. This word is used by Trachalio in answer to everything that Daemones says to him.

[111] Very well : Here Daemones begins to pay him in his own coin, and answers him with licet until he makes his exit.

[112] His very-welling : Cum suâ licentiâ. In the latter word he alludes to Trachalio having bored him with his licets, although, having given him a Roland for his Oliver, he might have surely been content with that.

[113] This booty seems to me : This passage is very obscure, and has been variously interpreted. He seems, however, to mean that more good will come of restoring the booty to its owner than of keeping it.

[114] So I reckon : For the sake of mere nonsense, Trachalio begins to trifle with his master, by giving him the

answer of censeo to everything he says; just as he gave his repeated answers of licet to Daemones before leaving

[115] Do carry over : At sume quidem, though not given by Fleckeisen, has been here adopted as the reading. Censeo seems to mean to reckon up, as well as to think. Salmasius and Gronovius suggest, and with fair reason, that he means jocularly to say, Don’t be always reckoning, but cast up and carry over.

[116] Closed his reckoning : Dilectum dimisit. This expression is explained by some Commentators as alluding to the enlisting of soldiers, to which the word censeo was applicable. The play on the word censeo throughout this Scene is enwrapt in great obscurity.

[117] Commissioned judges : Recuperatores. These were also called judices selecti, and were commissioned judges appointed by the Praetors at Rome for the purpose of trying causes relative to property in dispute between parties. See the Bacchides, l. 270.

[118] Has been drugged : He alludes to the rust which has eaten into the spit and worn it away.

[119] Your shorn pate : Madame Dacier suggests that Labrax has had his hair cut off in consequence of having escaped from shipwreck, which, indeed, was often done during the continuance of a storm by those at sea.

[120] A medicant : He plays upon the resemblance of the words medicus and mendicus. To give effect to the pun, we have, with Thornton, coined the word medicant, in the sense of doctor or physician.

[121] Hit it to a nicety : Tetigisti acu. Literally, you’ve hit it with the point —that is, exactly.

[122] You are cooling it : He is supposed here to allude to the act of drawing the breath into the mouth with the teeth half closed, which produces a sensation of coolness; meaning, that he doesn’t speak out and offer with boldness.

[123] Part of line 1328 in the Latin.

[124] I shall never beg : He says this to himself, meaning that he has a sufficient stock of perjury at home, without going to another person for it. See l. 558.

[125] Are you the priest : The meaning of this passage is doubtful, but he seems to ask Daemones, Are you the Priest of Venus, in whose presence I took the oath? It was probably the duty of the priesthood to take cognizance of cases of perjury.

[126] Five-and-twenty years old : By the Laetorian law (which is also referred to in the Notes to the Pseudolus), persons under the age of five-and-twenty were deemed minors, and free from all pecuniary obligations. As usual, in this allusion Plautus consults the usages of his Audience, and not of the place where the Scene is laid. Labrax is ready to say or swear anything; and Madame Dacier justly remarks, that it is amusing enough that he should call himself not five-and-twenty, when he is described, in the Second Scene of the First Act, as a person having grey hair. Gripus being a slave, could not try the question at law with Labrax.

[127] The other booty : By this he means the wallet and its contents.

[128] If I don’t hang myself : Thorntor calls this a sorry witticism; but Madame Dacier and other Commentators discover great humour in it It certainly is amusing for its absurdity.

[129] This Play, though pronounced to be one of the best of this author, does not conclude satisfactorily. We are not told what becomes of Ampelisca, or of Trachalio, who aspires to the honor of her hand. The sturdy Sceparnio we lose sight of too early; and Daemones loses all claim to our estimation, by inviting such an infamous villain as Labrax to take a place at his table, who certainly, according to the usual rules of dramatic retribution, richly deserves to lose his wallet and its contents.